RESEARCH AND DEVELOPMENT SERIES

The Composition, Challenges and Changes in the Top Team Structures of UK Higher Education Institutions

Development Report

Tom Kennie
Ranmore Consulting Group/Nottingham Business School

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

"I think most people would like it to be a community of scholars, but these days with the context in which we operate it has to be corporatist, more managerialist. I hope we don't lose the sense of purpose, and what we're trying to achieve. "

"I suppose I'd put all my money on having the right people, as we're a highly people focused organisation, and Universities only deliver ultimately through a high degree of cooperation and consensus building quite honestly, and not a lot through directives and instructions from management. Therefore the people element is vital, and if you've got the wrong chemistry, I think, regardless of the structure, it isn't going to work very well. The structures can complement and facilitate that and make it easier. It can be an obstacle presumably, but I think that the people aspect is the one that I would see as the most important. The technical, if there are technical deficiencies in any individual's knowledge base, you can plug those, but if an individual can't work with other senior colleagues, and position themselves appropriately, then no end of technical training will overcome that."

This report is based on the findings from a two-year research project, funded by the Leadership Foundation for Higher Education, focused on the composition and changes affecting the most senior level executive decision making bodies in UK higher education institutions (HEIs). The report draws upon desk based and empirical research evidence and extensive consultancy experience (with top teams) from within the higher education sector over a 5 year period.

The report has been written as a practical guide for Heads of Institutions (HOIs) and members of 'top teams' who are interested in the structures and operations of such teams in HEIs, either because they are seeking to restructure their own 'top team' or review its mode of operating. Hopefully, the report will also be of interest to researchers and higher education professionals who are interested in leadership, management and governance issues in higher education.

The report is structured into five sections. The first section provides an overview of the project including the rationale and context, the methodology and a discussion of some important terminological issues. The second section is a review of the key literature on 'top teams' drawn both from the higher education sector and other sectors. Section 3 discusses the main findings from the research - in particular it outlines some conceptual frameworks that were developed, and explores some of the changing patterns in the composition of roles found in TMTs - whilst Section 4 discusses some issues and guidelines for the 'architects of top teams' in HEIs. Section 5 concludes with some reflections on the findings, recommendations for further research and potential approaches to aid the leadership development of members of top teams. Finally, in Appendix A, a diagnostic questionnaire developed during the project to collect institutional information about top teams is provided, together with some introductory notes on its development and the outcomes of the piloting process.

Section 1 begins by outlining the **focus of the research** which was to explore the ways in which different higher education institutions have created their 'top management team' and senior management structures, and the reasons behind such developments. The research also sought to conceptualise the relevant implications of these changes to inform those involved in leading senior management restructuring within institutions. A number of key research questions which guided the project are also provided.

The **background and rationale** for the project is then described. In recent years, UK HEIs have been developing and implementing significant levels of structural change. This 'restructuring' differs between institutions, and ranges from a minor re-alignment of roles and responsibilities to more radical change that often involves the creation of new roles and new models of operating. Although top level teams would seem to be crucial to the strategic aspects of leadership, little is known about their form and structure, functions and effectiveness, or of the different models of top management in use.

The authors then outline the **data collection** approach used in the project which combined empirical 'case study' research in 17 HEIs (in depth interviews with members of the top team and review of institutional documents) with a literature review, supplemented with data collected workshop discussions with Top Management Programme (TMP) fellows and information from consultancy work with HEIs. The sample institutions were broadly representative of the sector and included comprehensive research intensive institutions, institutions in the post '92 part of the sector, smaller specialist organisations, together with private and 'for-profit' higher educational bodies. A detailed diagnostic questionnaire was also developed during the project (see Appendix A), and piloted with a small number of institutions.

A critical perspective on the concept of a TMT in a higher education context and a detailed analysis of the **terminology** used to define the TMT then follows. It is clear from the research that there are diverse understandings of the term 'top management team' in the higher education sector – some participants described the TMT as an informal or non-constitutional body, others viewed it as synonymous with a grouping of senior managers, whilst others claimed that such a body does not exist in their institution. It is also suggested that using the words 'top', 'management' and 'team' can be difficult in a higher education context since each word can mean different things in different institutions – these different meanings are discussed in detail. The conclusion is then drawn that using the term 'top management team' could be especially problematic in a higher education context since all three words in the phrase could either often be used pejoratively or be viewed as questionable for application in higher education.

Some of the more common **drivers and catalysts for change** in the structure and/or composition of the TMT are also identified. It was found that the architect of the top team structure is typically the HOI, and that they are likely to address the issues of top team change at various points during their tenure, either due to a need for a new strategic direction for the institution, or because of a perceived need to alter the membership or approach of the team. Less common are situations when one or more members of the team itself initiate and create the pressure for change, or when the team initiate and work with the HOI in order to reform, refresh or rationalise the TMT. The authors suggest that irrespective of the reason or motive behind the change, achieving the desired benefits without the undesired consequences requires careful thought and action.

The **literature summary** (Section 2) reviews some of the key research-based and other literature on the theme of 'top teams' and compares the extensive work on this topic in the corporate sector with the much more limited literature that relates directly to higher education. The authors found that much of the corporate sector literature focuses on the role of the Chief Executive Officer (CEO), the challenges that they face in structuring and 'managing' their top team, and the importance of creating the right balance between working intensively together as a 'real' team on strategically important activities and working separately, albeit with a collective focus, in their own areas of responsibility. The higher education sector literature tends to focus on how the top team can generate a sense of shared purpose in a context where strong central direction can conflict with the desire for devolution and more distributed or collaborative forms of leadership. The literature analysis concludes by providing a comparative perspective on the similarities and differences between TMTs in both sectors.

In Section 3, the focus shifts to the empirical research findings. Firstly, **three conceptual frameworks** are provided - based on the case studies and reviews of a range of existing structures in HEIs - which are designed to highlight the different types of structure identified in the higher education sector. The first framework presents some of the key functions of the top team using a matrix with two dimensions: strategic-operational and internal-external. The second framework describes four different types of TMT in a matrix form and provides examples of different TMTs based on the dimensions of style and function. The final framework is a typology of five alternative TMT structures in UK HEIs. The authors conclude that institutions that take a more 'structured' view will tend towards a more planned, top down approach to the TMT structure, whilst those drawn more to a people-orientated perspective are more likely to focus on a more emergent, adaptive, bottom up view of team development.

Section 3 also contains an analysis of the **changing role patterns** becoming apparent across a range of TMTs in higher education. In particular there is evidence of significant changes to the nature and status of roles such as: deputy vice-chancellor/deputy principal; pro-vice-chancellor/vice-principal; registrar (and secretary); heads of professional services; and deans. A further emergent trend across a number of institutions is the establishment of new senior management level roles that have different levels of influence on top management (e.g. pro-provost; adviser to the HOI; assistant vice-chancellor). Some clear differences in role representation and definitions within 'pre '92 institutions and 'post 92' institutions also emerged and these are examined in detail.

In Section 4, we identify and discuss in detail 16 practical **issues for consideration and guidelines for action**. The guidelines are intended to assist HOIs and 'top team' members seeking to respond to the challenges of adapting their top team structures and to help them avoid or limit the unintended effects of incorrectly handled 'restructuring' exercises. The guidelines start by focusing on 'the what' of top team working (motives, roles, and functions) before moving on to 'the how' of team working (alignment of agendas, team roles, communication and other process issues. Architects are encouraged to undertake a more

holistic review involving all 16 issues rather than focus on a limited number of issues since they tend to be interrelated. The importance of considering the formal as well as the informal aspects of top team structures is also highlighted.

Guideline 1 focuses on the **rationale and motive(s) for changes to the TMT.** It provides a typology of different rationales for change and highlights the need to understand the 'real' issues surrounding the need for change to the TMT. In our experience these are rarely discussed internally, and there is often a need to discuss this issue with someone external to the institution.

Guideline 2 outlines some of the key **role(s) and role expectations of top team members**. It is suggested that these need to be identified by the architects of the top team as an important foundation for building the capacities needed for the future, as well as identifying any gaps which might exist which can be addressed through development activities or recruitment.

Guideline 3 highlights the **need for the top team to clarify areas of decision making and time management**. It is important for a TMT to identify those issues on which it is crucial that the TMT operate collectively as a 'real' team and to ensure that adequate time is being devoted to these issues rather than those that are best left to other bodies.

Guideline 4 outlines the importance of **devoting sufficient collective time to consideration of succession management** in the top team. The research findings indicate that a more explicit and structured approach to succession into, and exit, from the TMT is becoming a much more significant issue for many HEIs. We recommend that succession issues should be discussed on an annual basis by the TMT.

Guideline 5 suggests **understanding the location of the HOI in their career trajectory** is crucial for the top team. We provide seven examples of career stages for the HOI and describe the implications of each for the effective working of the top team.

Guideline 6 shifts the focus to the **career trajectory of TMT members**. The authors recommend that the TMT should regularly review the 'talent' required for the TMT and consider the capabilities necessary for the future, either as part of a regular personal development, planning and appraisal process, or as part of a more holistic process designed to take a collective view of the overall pool of talent and capabilities across the TMT (and wider SMG).

Guideline 7 recommends that top team architects make time in the early stages of team formation (and reformation) to integrate new members and to help **enhance the degree of team working and collective agenda setting**. Teamwork doesn't 'just happen' and team formation and team-working are crucial to the effective working of the top team.

Guideline 8 focuses on the need for **consideration and routine review of the process of communication** between the TMT and its wider constituents.

Guideline 9 highlights the need for the TMT to devote time to assessing collectively how the process of **connecting to the Council / Board** is being handled. Inconsistencies, ambiguities or conflicting agendas will ultimately limit the likelihood and speed of successful implementation of specific agendas. It may also potentially reflect badly on the effectiveness of the leader in developing effective team working in his/her top team.

Guideline 10 suggests that it is crucial for the TMT to **effectively communicate 'sideways' with other 'top teams'** within the institution. Higher education differs from other contexts in having a number of 'top teams' or their equivalent (e.g. Senate, Academic Board, particular committees). It is important for the TMT to consider which other internal bodies are of most significance and to ensure that the TMT is well connected with the agenda and activities of each sub-group. Even the most successful TMT will fail if they do not build connections with other (formal and informal) teams in the institution. The number of connections necessary will therefore vary depending on the structure of the institution.

Guideline 11 recommends that the TMT regularly reviews how it **connects 'outwards' with external stakeholders** in terms of regularly checking the internal conduits for upward communication about external links from others in the institution. Much of the work of the TMT involves connecting formally and informally with external stakeholders. These include Funding Bodies, Research Councils, and Regional Development Agencies, the political (and planning) bodies at a town/city level, national or regional representative bodies, and formal partnerships/alliances.

Guideline 12 highlights the importance of **establishing a shared understanding of the behaviours which enable effective team working** (when this is vitally important). We recommend that top team architects review the top team more frequently and consider the expressive and cognitive

aspects of its working, consider and discuss the degree of complementarity which exists within the team and consider whether a more explicit set of behavioural 'ground rules' might help the team to operate even more effectively.

Guideline 13 suggests that **the location of the top team matters**. We highlight that the physical location of the top team sends important political and symbolic signals to the institution about both the role and importance of the top team. If the top team is co-located, they can benefit from regular informal interactions and could be perceived as a more collective body rather than a grouping of representatives from throughout the institution.

Following on from the previous guidelines, Guideline 14 suggests that **the logistical support and resources available to the top team also matters**. If the TMT is well-resourced (e.g. executive assistants, programme managers, change managers, and project managers) they may be able to undertake particular strategic tasks (e.g. internal research, scoping studies) without having to seek support from elsewhere in the institution.

Guideline 15 focuses on **the importance of individual and collective performance management related to top team working.** The research demonstrated that performance management at the collective level in a TMT is a much less well developed process - even more so when the matter of reward is added. We recommend that TMTs discuss explicitly the performance management processes and evaluation techniques they plan to use, how much time they plan to devote to this issue, who should participate and how frequently they should undertake the activity at an individual and collective level.

Guideline 16 calls for TMTs to **consider their development as a team**. This involves engaging routinely in collective processes which offer insights into the team's working patterns, and allow 'taken for granted' assumptions about the way the team works to be discussed. Team development as an explicit process for TMTs in HEIs is a relatively new activity. Many teams, once they are formed, are then left to their own devices rather than engaging in an ongoing team development processes which can enhance team performance for the benefit of the whole HEI.

Section 5 concludes with reflections on key issues identified in the project, identifies some issues which could benefit from further research and suggests some areas for leadership development for top teams. This final section concludes by providing a 'review framework' summarising the key guidelines together with proposals for action for use by TMTs to reflect on, and guide, their approach to change.

The **three reflections** on key issues emerging from the project are summarised below:

The first focuses on 'who' should be the architect of the top team – traditionally it is the HOI. We suggest that this is wholly appropriate at some times (e.g. when he/she is new to the institution, or when a particular team member is under-performing). However, when the TMT has worked together for some time, when the need for collective action is required, and when the views and opinions of the whole team are important, then there is a strong case for decisions relating to the team to be taken by the team.

The second relates to the relative importance of the formal top team structure compared with more informal networks. The research has shown that the many and varied informal networks which permeate a HEI can be highly influential and which could have a disproportionate impact that might be perceived from their location in the formal hierarchy of decision making bodies. The ability both to acknowledge and engage, in a constructive sense with these informal networks of stakeholder groups, without creating a subversive alternative cabinet, is perhaps an important feature of the more effective TMTs.

The third describes the concept of 'structured networks' and suggests that this may provide an alternative to the more conventional hierarchical and matrix forms of structure found in many HEIs. The benefits of a structured network TMT would be to recognise the importance of collective working without moving fully towards a strongly hierarchical, top down approach.

We then suggest the following **areas where there would be value in conducting further research** related to top teams.

Proposal 1: sector-wide survey(s) on top team structures – e.g. similar types of institutions might wish to consider the value of more limited surveys of their members using a variant of the questionnaire instrument outlined in the Appendix to this report. We believe this could be a value added service to their members and a process which could be of real benefit to the sector.

Proposal 2: more detailed research on a limited number of roles in the TMT which are identified as facing significant change (e.g. deans, heads of professional services, and the registrar) and to consider the impact these changing roles on the composition of the TMT.

Proposal 3: an investigation into the strengths and weaknesses of the alternative approaches currently used for the recruitment, selection and induction of top team members. This could also usefully involve further work involving 'search and selection' agencies which are active in the higher education market.

Proposal 4: further work to review the current approaches to linking reward to individual, team and institutional performance at the most senior levels in HEIs.

Proposal 5: a study of the range of team development techniques currently in use in the higher education sector to assist the development of TMTs.

As Proposal 6 the authors also provide a number of suggestions for **future leadership development specifically targeted at TMT members**, which could usefully be provide by the Leadership Foundation. These are grouped into three main areas:

Executive Coaching – a small, but increasing number of HEIs offer members of the TMT access to an external coach typically on their appointment to the TMT and during their early period in the role. There could be value gained from evaluating the experience to date of this type of process and to broaden the extent of such support beyond its current provision.

Top Team Induction & Skills Development – A growing number of HEIs provide opportunities for senior staff to participate in leadership development experiences, often in collaboration with colleagues in other institutions. A limited number of short programmes exclusively for those about who have just joined or are about to enter the TMT could usefully be provided to supplement the induction processes within the institution.

Cross Sector and International Comparisons - gaining insights into the workings of TMT by looking at TMTs in other public (or private sectors), or in a very different cultural context. In the former there may be value in understanding how TMTs in other 'intellect based organisations' (e.g. professional service firms, research organisations etc.) operate.

Section 5 concludes with a final **summary of the guidelines and proposals for action** in tabular form, for use as a review framework. The authors suggest that TMT architects review all guidelines and proposals and that the issue of issue of 'Top Team Working' should be on their agenda, on at least an annual basis, as team working at the top is too important an issue to be left to chance.

The appendix contains a detailed **questionnaire survey tool** which was developed for use during the research and piloted with a small number of institutions. The tool is designed to be used by individual institutions, or consortia of institutions for comparative benchmarking studies. The questionnaire was initially designed for the purpose of undertaking a sector wide survey on top teams; however the piloting exercise confirmed that the questionnaire was best used as an institutional tool for self-evaluation.

1 INTRODUCTION

This project is focused on examining the changes and challenges associated with the design, formation and working practices of 'top management teams' (TMTs) in UK higher education institutions (HEIs). It seeks to explore the ways in which different institutions have created their 'top management team' and senior management structures, and the reasons behind such developments. It also seeks to conceptualise the relevant implications of these changes to inform those involved in leading senior management restructuring within institutions.

The report is intended to be a practical guide for use by heads of institutions (HOIs) and members of 'top teams'. It draws upon research evidence and is also informed by extensive consultancy experience (with top teams) from within the higher education sector over a 5 year period. In the context of the research and development series, this must be considered to be more weighted towards 'development' informed by research. The project uses evidence drawn from some 17 different HEIs which are broadly representative of the sector, ranging from comprehensive research intensive institutions, institutions in the post '92 part of the sector, smaller specialist organisations, together with private and 'for-profit' higher educational bodies.

The report is designed to respond to the following questions:

- What is a TMT?
- Why is change occurring in the some TMTs?
- What expectations do relevant stakeholders have of the TMT?
- Who, typically, are its members?
- How does it operate?
- How does it connect and communicate with other relevant bodies (internal and external to the institution)?
- What can be influenced or changed in order to enhance team working in the TMT?

In order to answer these and other questions, the report is structured into five key sections;

Section 1 explores the rationale for the project and the approach adopted to investigate the issues. This section then moves on to define the terminology used throughout the report. In addition the authors then identify some of the forces which are leading to change in 'top teams'

Section 2 then reviews the literature on the subject. A comparative analysis is undertaken to compare and contrast the extensive literature in the corporate sector with the much more limited evidence from the higher education sector.

Section 3 synthesises the findings and offers several more generic conceptual frameworks relating to the forms of TMTs to be found in the higher education sector. This is then extended to explore some of the changing patterns in the composition of roles found in TMTs.

Section 4 is a guide to inform action for HOI and top teams. It identifies some 16 practical issues which HOI and top teams would be wise to consider when undertaking changes to their structure.

Section 5 concludes with some reflections on conducting this type of research, identifies five issues which could benefit from further research and suggests some areas for leadership development for top teams. This final section concludes by providing a 'review framework' summarising the key guidelines together with proposals for action for use by TMTs to reflect on, and guide, their approach to change.

A comprehensive questionnaire survey tool developed for the project is provided in Appendix A. The process of reviewing the outcomes from the questionnaire (within a single institution, or comparatively across a range of comparative institutions) could, we believe, offer some helpful insights that can aid the review and redesign of their TMT.

1.1 Background and rationale

The term 'top management team' relates to the most senior level of executive decision making within an organisation[1]. In the context of higher education in the UK, the TMT is known by a variety of different titles (e.g. the Executive Board, the Vice-Chancellors Advisory Group, the Directorate, Chancellery, etc). Although top level teamwork would seem to be crucial to the strategic aspects of leadership, little is known about the form and structure, functions and effectiveness, of the different models of top management in use, either related to the TMT or to the wider senior management structures within higher education institutions.

During the last five to ten years, UK HEIs have been developing and implementing significant levels of structural change, influenced by internal and external policy developments and a rapidly changing global operating context. These include: the development of larger academic units; expansion of activities; increasing international and/or regional responsibilities; and a need for co-

1 Ancona & Nadler (1989)

ordination of a greater variety of operational units. These changes also reflect an increasingly professional approach to institutional management characterised by a move from 'the academic civil service'[2] to 'the administration'[3], to the 'entrepreneurial university'[4] with its central 'steering core' to the more fluid, more devolved and less hierarchical models[5].

At the top management level, both formal and informal structures and relationships appear to be undergoing significant changes, and the senior management structure of many institutions is being re-framed or conceptually restructured. This 'restructuring' differs between institutions, and ranges from minor re-alignment of roles and responsibilities to more radical change that often involves the creation of new roles and new models of operating[6].

For example, in many instances we observed a two-level 'top team structure' has evolved with a small 'inner cabinet' taking responsibility for day-to-day decision making, whilst a wider senior management group which often meets less frequently makes decisions on longer term issues. This can take different forms and some of the different forms of TMT are described in Section 3. There is also a suggestion that the balance of power between the various formal and informal groups at the senior management level is changing, and that identifying the locus of power and influence within senior management has become more difficult and complex, making it also less easy to define those individuals and groups responsible for developing and delivering university strategy and operations[7]. In addition, such arrangements may also bring communication, role definition, accountability and other challenges within institutions that may impact ultimately upon the effective functioning of senior management at all levels[8].

1.2 Approach and methodology

The research approach that was adopted combined empirical investigation in a sample of HEIs, desk-based research of literature and other relevant documentary information supplemented by practical experience through consulting projects to work with a range of top teams in the higher education (and other sectors).

The desk research phase involved collecting and analysing background data and research literature to inform the project and help the researchers develop conceptual frameworks and emergent issues to investigate in more depth in the empirical phase of the research. It is interesting to note that the desk research revealed that publicly available information (e.g. statistical data from the Higher Education Statistics Agency (HESA)) is not organised in such a way as to make it straightforward to identify and profile senior managers in the UK university sector.

The empirical research involved a combination of semi-structured interviews with 1 or 2 top managers in a small sample of 17 institutions from across the UK (around 10% of all HEIs) in early 2006, and a more limited questionnaire survey that was distributed to all HEIs in the UK in late 2006/early 2007. The types of information about TMTs that was collected in the empirical stages of the research is summarised in Table 1 opposite. The findings from the desk research and an initial analysis of the interview data are discussed in this report.

1.3 Defining terms: what is a 'top management team' in a HEI?

> *"….the vice-chancellor is a very powerful personality, [….]. To some extent, it is a bit like a benevolent dictatorship, and you know, he does say, well ultimately I can do whatever I like, although I listen to you."*

Defining the body which is perceived to be the 'top management team' in an HEI is an interesting and somewhat problematic question. Ask a random sample of staff in any institution and you are likely to receive a range of different responses. Some respondents (probably those in formal 'management' positions) will cite the group of senior post holders who meet with the head of institution on a regular basis. This may have a formal title (e.g. the Executive Board, the Directorate, the Vice-Chancellors Group, the Chief Executives Group, etc.).

Others may cite a more informal group who meet to discuss the future agenda for the institution. This may or may not have a formal title (one we have come across is the 'Monday Morning Meeting').

> *"I don't think anybody much knows about the Monday Meetings that we have, because we always gloss those as office meetings,[…..] just to talk about stuff that's to do with managing the senior management team, conceived as an office that does the business [….] Monday Meetings are not always on Mondays"*

2 Sloman (1964)
3 Shattock (1970)
4 Clark (1998)
5 Whitchurch (2004)
6 Whitchurch (2006)
7 Lambert (2003); Middlehurst (2004)
8 Whitchurch (2006)

TABLE 1

INFORMATION ON TMTS COLLECTED IN THE INTERVIEWS AND QUESTIONNAIRE SURVEY

FACTS AND DATA	PROCESSES AND PRACTICES
Size	Communication to / from
Scale	Succession management
Roles	Meeting organisation
Responsibilities / Portfolios	Induction & exit
Background of post holders	Interaction
Terms of Reference	Team development
Reporting lines	Performance evaluation
Period of appointment	Renewal
Accountability lines	Internal and external relationships

Despite the fact that some TMTs may be described as informal bodies, one should not interpret this as implying any lack of importance. Others may identify the 'senior management team' as the top team, typically a very large group of senior post holders from both academic and professional services functions who meet relatively infrequently (monthly, quarterly, or even biannually). Finally, others may find the question difficult to answer as the following quotes illustrate.

"Top? Management? Team!? - no idea I'm sorry, you might like to try asking someone else?"

"Team? Top? – no sorry can't think who that would be".

1.3.1 Some definitional challenges

"Yes, I mean, first of all who is the top team, who is in the senior management team, there's always a row about who is in the senior management team. I think I bypassed that to a certain extent, by saying there's an Executive Committee and a Senate. I don't talk in terms of a senior team."

To understand why it might legitimately be a somewhat difficult question to answer we need firstly to define our terms. By the use of the word 'Top' in this context we are referring to the most senior executive decision making body in the institution. 'Management' we are using to refer to the composite of senior role post holders who have been given delegated authority by the governing body or equivalent in the institution to manage (and lead) the institution. 'Team' we use to describe the collective positive group working behaviours demonstrated by these post holders when they are working jointly to an agreed agenda. As we can perhaps infer from the respondents above, each element of our descriptor has its difficulties in a higher education context.

'*Top*' suggests a pre-dominant and possibly singular consolidated power base for executive decision making. In some HEIs this is both acknowledged and valued but, in others, it would be highly contested territory. In the latter case, the implied loss of collegial decision making and the perceived concentration of power in a small number of people would mitigate against any single 'top' group being recognised (even in cases where it has become formally constituted).

Similar problems may arise with the interpretations of '*management*'. Again, depending on the context, this can be judged to be a positive process for taking decisions to clarify a strategy, allocate (limited) resources, plan implementation and eventually hold individuals to account for the delivery of the agreed strategy. The argument would be made that these are a very necessary and important set of generic processes which enable complex organisations to operate effectively and efficiently. Without clear lines of accountability and line management authority it is not possible to assure stakeholders, manage risks and consistently deliver the right outcomes to students and customers. In other contexts the notion of 'management' will be much less 'corporate' in its application. Strategy will be much more emergent, resource allocation much more negotiated than allocated and implementation and monitoring achieved more collectively. The 'mental models' associated with 'management' are clearly somewhat different in both cases.

Sometimes the use of management language may be more cosmetic than real.

> *"It's called the University Management Team. They changed the name about a couple of years ago, because they wanted to make it sound more like it was part of the University. Corporate Management Team sounded a bit distant, so obviously it was just a small kind of gesture, I think, towards finding inclusivity really"*

When we come to the final element 'team', further complications arise. Typically the term 'team' has associated with it some, if not all, of the following characteristics[9]. A (real) team has;

- a collective task that demands a high level of *interdependency* among its members, that
- is something that can only be *accomplished together*,
- Has clear and *stable boundaries* and membership that is not *constantly changing*,
- people with *complementary skills* who are
- committed to a *common purpose*,
- *have jointly agreed performance goals* and have an approach for which they hold themselves *mutually accountable*.

In the majority of cases we contend, many of these conditions do not reflect the way in which the '*top team*' operates. Often the collective, common purpose for the TMT (as opposed to the institution) is not as well articulated, complementarily in role and behavioural terms may occur (but is often very limited), membership is more often subject to quite frequent change, performance goals may exist but are often implicit rather than explicit and accountability is more often of an individual nature and the concept of mutual accountability much less common.

To demonstrate the different mental model of 'team work' which exists in (some) higher education contexts we quote as follows;

> *"I thought of myself as quite a good team worker. Using a football analogy I saw myself as a strong midfield player. Pick up the ball – move it on to someone who was in a better position – help move things forward. But it didn't seem to work like that. Increasingly I kept being asked 'why are you giving me the ball'? 'Can't you give it to someone else? Or why not do it yourself? Increasingly I recognised my metaphor for team working was wrong. Then it struck me. It wasn't a football team I was in – I suddenly noticed that one of the 'team players' was running faster and faster around the track, another was trying to jump higher – and another was throwing a long pointed instrument as far as he could (trying not to hit the others – but I wasn't always so sure)."*

One further example might help to highlight the differing context of top team working in the higher education context. Consider the historical differences involved in the process of appointing a new senior academic member to the top team compared to a more 'corporate business context' using the following thought experiment. Imagine you are the new Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of a £100m business, with a capital investment plan of over £200m over the next three years. How would you select a new strategic leader to become a member of your top team and assist you with your organisational challenges?

The following is one possible process you might have (historically) found used in the higher education sector.

- First you don't advertise the post externally,
- Second, you may - but more frequently do not - interview any of the applicants or potential candidates.
- Third, you select the candidate on the basis of the need to have someone from a particular Unit (Faculty/Department/Discipline) on the team,
- Fourth, you probably expect the person selected to have a strong track record in some area relatively unconnected to the portfolio on which they will have to deliver (e.g. research).
- Fifth, you expect the person selected to do the job on a

9 Katzenbach and Smith, (1993)

part-time basis (say 3 days per week),

- Sixth, you are unlikely to provide any induction or training for the role,
- Seventh, you are unlikely to provide the appointed person with any budgetary resources or a personal assistant (PA).
- Eighth, you may often pay them less than many of your 'middle managers'
- Finally, you know they will be expected to stand down from the role just as they become proficient (in about 2-3 years from now!).

It is now (thankfully?) - the case that many more senior posts are advertised externally, for search and selection to be used, for much more rigorous recruitment and selection techniques to be used, and for posts to be either on a permanent or on a fixed-term basis with a much longer initial period – typically 5 years.

1.4 What drives change in top teams in higher education?

"I think more or less every head of institution comes in and rearranges the furniture in senior management, and I suspect that will continue to be the case."

The architect of the top team structure is typically the HOI. As we progress through this report, however, we question whether the 'top down' model is necessarily the most effective in all cases, and indeed whether a more emergent, team based approach may have advantages in a number of contexts. We return to this hypothesis in our conclusion.

The need or urgent requirement to introduce changes in the TMT structure can arise at various points in the tenure of a HOI. For some, the issue dominates their thinking from the moment of appointment. The perceived need for change may have been diagnosed or highlighted during the selection process and the signal or sense that swift, decisive action is required or demanded becomes a major driver in the short term.

For others, the issue emerges during the first year in office, typically as a necessary response to a new or emerging strategy. Changes in portfolios in the top team become necessary to align activity (or people) to the new or emergent strategic priorities.

A further catalyst for change in the top team structure may arise on the retirement, promotion or end of a fixed term appointment (where these exist) for one or more of the existing team, or when a key member leaves for another post elsewhere. The opportunity to 'take stock' and consider whether a direct replacement is needed or whether more radical surgery is necessary arises. Avoiding 'losing the baby' as the bathwater is changed can become a challenge at this transition point.

For other HOIs the point of change is simply part of an ongoing process of evolutionary adaptation. No major restructuring takes place, just a constant shuffling and re-ordering of the cards as the 'game' develops.

Although relatively uncommon, the more radical - in some instances, cataclysmic and quick - removal of a perceived underperforming member of the team or of an entire 'cabinet' can also precipitate serious 'restructuring' of other parts of the HEI.

Whilst much less common, a further important driver of change in the top team can occur when one or more members of the team themselves initiate and create the pressure for change. This type of change may be a response to a number of perceived concerns. First, it may be related to the desire of the individual or the team to introduce changes in roles or the role portfolios at a quicker pace than is perceived necessary by the HOI. Second, it may be in response to a perceived lack of performance in relation to one or more members of the team and an apparent lack of urgency or visible evidence of this being addressed by the HOI. Third, it may be driven by a much more political agenda – either to highlight to those in governance positions the performance of the HOI, or it may be a demonstration by some of a desire to be considered as a strong contender for the HOI position.

A further, less common but potentially valuable, rationale for change may occur when the team initiate and work with the HOI in order to reform, refresh or rationalise the TMT. This approach can sometimes also occur in advance of a new HOI arriving, typically when a very mature and long standing TMT perceives the need to 'get its house in order' before the new leader arrives. Much less common is for the team to work with a new HOI to undertake a similar review in the early stages of the new team's existence.

Whatever the reason or motive behind the change, achieving the *desired benefits* without the *undesired consequences* requires careful thought and action. We return to the issue of motives later in the report.

2 SUMMARY OF THE LITERATURE

There is a well-developed body of literature on the form and structure of TMTs in other sectors, however, to date, there has been much less written about top teams in the context of higher education.

2.1 Corporate sector literature

In the corporate or business context, the scope of the literature ranges from studies of the role of the CEO and the early challenges associated with those new in role [10], to wider studies of strategic leadership and the role of the top executives [11]. Others, such as Hambrick [12], have identified common problems which CEOs experienced within corporate TMTs, which include inadequate capabilities of individual executives, mismatches between the skills and talents of the TMT and the changing external environment, harmful rivalries between individuals, the danger of 'group think' where an 'excessive like-mindedness and striving for unanimity exists in highly cohesive groups' and the converse, 'fragmentation' where individual fiefdoms or domains lead to a lack of collective accountability.

Other studies have sought to identify the extent to which the TMTs composition has an impact on strategic change. Wiersema & Bantel [13] found 'that firms most likely to undergo changes in corporate strategy had TMTs characterised by, lower average age of team members, shorter organisational tenure, higher team tenure, higher educational level, higher educational specialisation heterogeneity, and higher academic training in the sciences than other teams'.

More recently Jarzabkowski & Searle [14] have also emphasised the importance of both 'diversity' (in demographic, functional and behavioural terms) and 'collective action' in enhancing the 'strategic capacity' of the TMT. They further suggest that the following six inter-related processes are necessary to develop this capacity in TMTs: 1) valuing diversity through diversity evaluation; 2) developing super-ordinate goals involving high levels of active participation; 3) learning as opposed to blaming; 4) regular process review; 5) external facilitation and; 6) leadership, which highlights the active role of the CEO in establishing the right climate and conditions for team working and in understanding the impact of the CEO on TMT dynamics.

Other recent studies in the broader business context have examined the role of TMT 'behavioural integration' in explaining the quality of strategic decisions and how these constructs influenced organisational decline [15]. Hambrick defines 'behavioural integration' as a 'meta-construct' that encompasses group processes such as social integration (often called group cohesion), and the frequency and quality of member exchanges and collaboration. Carmeli & Schaubroeck [16], hypothesised that 'a behaviourally integrated TMT is characterised by intense interaction that produces open information exchange and collaboratively based solutions and decisions'. Their findings from 116 TMT cases show that TMTs in which members reported higher behavioural integration made better strategic decisions and were negatively related to organisational decline.

One of the most comprehensive and interesting examinations of the 'seductive notion' of top teams is offered by Katzenbach [17]. Whilst based on the experience of interviews and consulting work with Fortune 500 companies in the USA, some of the findings and conclusions, as we will illustrate, reasonate with our own findings. Katzenbach's conclusions can be summarised in four main areas;

- The myths of top team working
- Why non-team working prevails at the top
- The trade-offs top teams need to consider
- The acknowledgement that team working at the top is required but not on all occasions

The myths of top team working he identified are summarised in Table 2 (opposite).

His second interesting set of insights relates to why 'non-team', individually focused behaviour predominates at the top. In summary he highlights the following;

- A meaningful purpose for the top team is more elusive than those which exist for individual members of the team
- Performance goals for the top team are often much less tangible than those for individuals – team goals reflect a much more complex cornucopia of choices. In the HE context the multiple criteria by which 'institutional success' is assessed compounds the challenge of establishing clear goals for the top team.

10 Porter et al. (2004)
11 Finkelstein & Hambrick (1996)
12 Hambrick (1995)
13 Wiersema & Bantel (1992)
14 Jarzabkowski & Searle (2004)
15 Hambrick (1994); Carmeli & Schaubroeck (2006)
16 Carmeli & Schaubroeck (2006)
17 Katzenbach (1998)

TABLE 2

MYTHS AND REALITIES OF TEAMS AT THE TOP (KATZENBACH, 1998)	
REAL TEAM MYTHS	**THE REALITIES**
Teamwork at the top will lead to team performance	Teamwork is not the same thing as team performance and often obscures real team performance opportunities.
Top teams need to spend more time together building consensus	Leaders have very little time, and many decisions are best made individually; real teams do not always seek consensus or conflict reduction.
CEO's must change their personal style to obtain team performance.	Team performance depends on the CEO's attitudes, beliefs and roles – not on personal style.
The senior team should function together as a team whenever it is together.	Most senior leadership interactions are not real team opportunities and do not warrant the application of team discipline.
Teams at the top need to 'set the example'.	Most real teams at lower levels are unaffected by how the senior leadership group behaves – as long as it is supportive of teams below.
It is a team because they say so!	The senior staff who report directly to the CEO seldom, if ever, function as a real team on an ongoing basis.

- Complementary skills give way to position – the senior leadership group is presumed to have all the necessary skills for any issue it chooses to pursue (which is clearly not always the case).
- The working approach of the team will need to accommodate part-time members – and recognise how to engage with them when their working patterns may be different.
- Mutual accountability is threatening – individual accountability is much clearer and many senior executives have less experience of mutual accountability.
- Non-teams fit the power structure – non-team behaviour protects 'the natural order of things' in the hierarchy.
- Non-teams are often faster and more efficient - in many cases the 'single-leader' working group can get things done much faster, as long as the leader really does 'know what is best' in terms of goals and working approaches.
- Fragmentation precludes collective work – top teams often do little collective work defined as 'the tangible result of several members of a group applying their different skills to produce a performance improvement not achievable by any one member alone'[18].

Thirdly, Katzenbach identifies three critical 'trade-offs' or dilemmas for TMTs and the need for these to be addressed consciously;

- **The time trade-off** - performance versus speed. The issue of deciding when the value of collective time together really is critical.
- **The capability trade-off** - complementary skill mix versus formal 'position influence'. The issue of judging when might I (or we) need to bring into the team non-members with skills we need to address key issues.
- **The capacity trade-off** - leadership capacity versus leadership clarity. The issue of when is there value in shifting the leader role amongst the members rather than depending on a single leader.

The final relevant observation from Katzenbach is that top teams have to recognise when they need to apply team disciplines and when to use a 'single leader working group' approach. Which option to use at which time is summarised in Figure 1 overleaf;

18 Katzenback (1998) p56

FIGURE 1

LEADERSHIP APPROACHES (KATZENBACH, 1998)

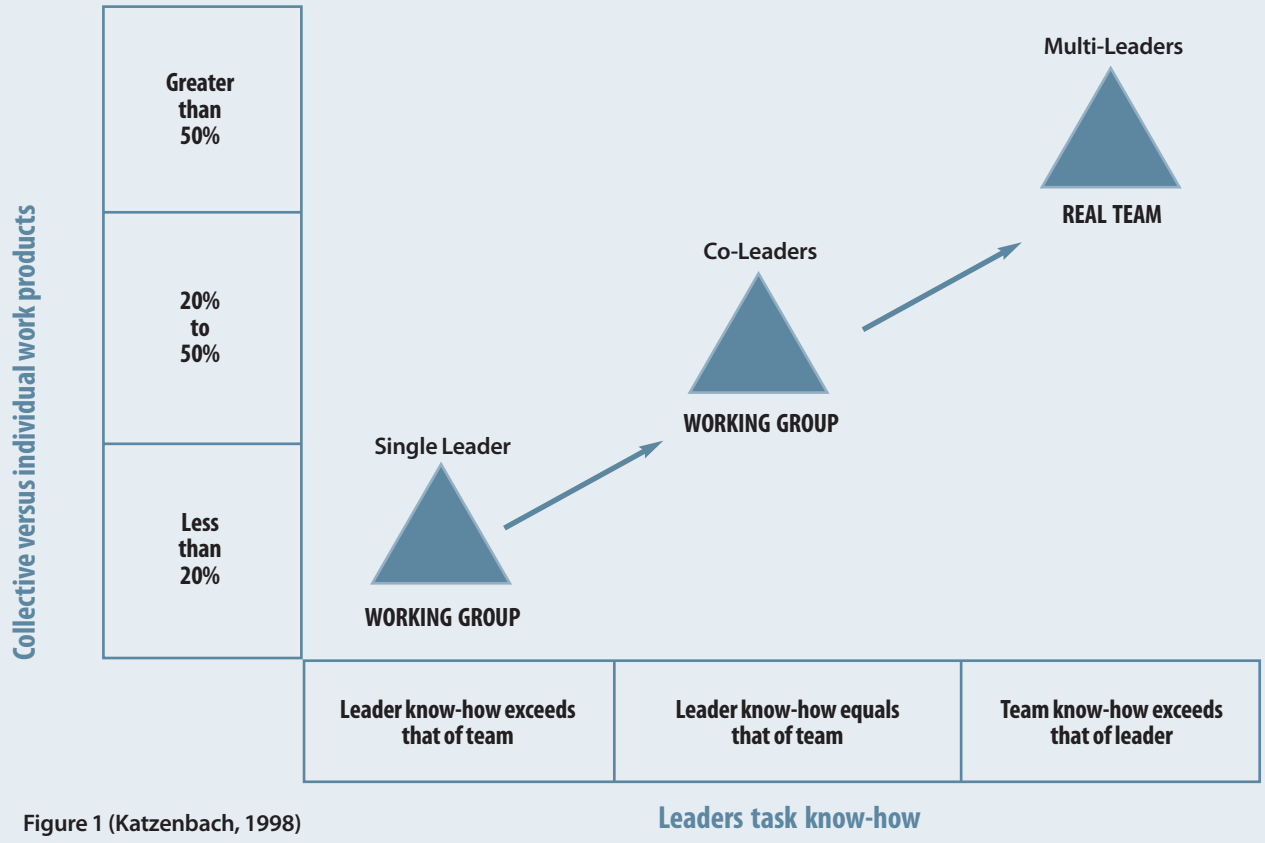


Figure 1 (Katzenbach, 1998)

Katzenbach concludes by making the case for the integration of the following three core activities for a top team:

1. **Discipline** – integrating real team performance and individual executive leadership.

2. **Alignment** – aligning both the formal and informal mechanisms to connect behaviours and decisions, and

3. **Balance** – blending the benefits of alternative working approaches (real team, single leader working group and individual working) to optimise leadership capacity and performance.

A further interesting source which offers some further insight into why team working is often absent at the top of organisations is Lencioni[19]. Lencioni highlights five common dysfunctions in teams.

Absence of trust

Essentially, this stems from an unwillingness to be vulnerable within the group. Team members who are not genuinely open with one another about their mistakes and weaknesses and this makes it difficult to build a foundation for trust.

Fear of conflict

Teams which lack trust, often lack an ability to engage in unfiltered and passionate debate about ideas. This fear of conflict leads to veiled discussions and guarded comments. Political behaviour dominates.

Lack of commitment

Lencioni then argues that this lack of healthy conflict leads to a lack of commitment. Without having aired their opinions in the course of passionate and open debate, team members rarely, if ever 'buy in' and commit to decisions, though they may feign agreement during meetings.

Avoidance of accountability

Without committing to a clear plan of collective action even the most focussed and driven people often hesitate to hold their peers to account on actions and behaviours that seem counterproductive to the good of the team.

19 Lenconi (2002) p56

Inattention to results

Finally, a lack of attention to collective results is prevalent, team members put their individual needs (ego, career development, the needs of their Unit above the collective goals of the team.

Despite its apparent simplicity the analysis is persuasive and the evidence in practice quite common. Taking the five dysfunctions further it is interesting to reflect on why they may be even more apparent in the context of higher education. These are best considered in reverse order.

Inattention to results

The lack of attention to collective results is perhaps even more challenging in a higher education context. First, measuring performance and defining success is often a much more complex and multi-dimensional issue than in a conventional business context (especially in certain areas – e.g. student experience, internationalisation). Second, in many instances, the incentives and rewards to work towards achieving joint collective outputs are often missing or lead to perverse non-team behaviour. For example, many TMTs are now operating some form of performance related pay (PRP) scheme. In practice many of these payment systems are not linked to collective outcomes (typically being focused mostly, if not exclusively, on the delivery of individual objectives). Surely at the top level of the organisation any PRP should be aligned to the delivery of institutional outcomes?

Given this perverse disincentive to work on collective outputs is it not quite logical to operate according to the behaviours which get most rewarded?

Avoidance of accountability

The avoidance of holding team members to account for non-team behaviours is also, for a number of reasons, more highly developed at the top levels of higher education. First, typically the process of holding members to account is in the vast majority of cases considered to be the job of the HOI. Any notion of a collective accountability is largely absent. Why might this be the case? Well in the first instance it is the HOI's team. He/She appoints individuals, if not on a fixed term basis, on an expectation that their term in office is heavily dependent on the patronage of the HOI. Should the HOI move (or be moved) all senior post holders are 'at risk' and recognise that a new HOI will be likely to review their senior team. Second, (and linked to the point above), the objectives which are negotiated are typically very much focused around individual portfolios, not collective institutional goals (even when objectives cross portfolio boundaries). Third, in many instances top team members have not discussed how to hold each other to account. Often attempts to do so fail because of the time, place and process of doing so is less than clear (i.e. transparent reviews, appraisals, 360 degree feedback). Instead corridor conversations take place complaining about the lack of action by the HOI, rather than a collective conversation being held to discuss breaches of team accountability where this is deemed critical. This also leads to a lack of collective accountability in relation to reviewing performance as a team.

Lack of commitment

The lack of team results and a process for holding the team to account is further amplified by the lack of commitment or buy-in which often exists in relation to team goals. Commitment to individual goals is typically very high. Top team members are individually highly successful; they are used to delivering results and will go to extraordinary lengths to deliver on their individual objectives. The impact of delivering on these individual objectives on other institutional goals may be acknowledged but often can lead to contradictory outcomes and a serious lack of 'joined-up' thinking and action. Examples abound – a high focus on maximising time on research excellence and the delivery of the research strategy, without at the same time considering the importance of time being invested in providing quality feedback as part of the 'student experience'. Or the sensible suggestion that as part of the 'third stream' strategy the institution should reduce its reliance on government funding and engage with employers. All fine so far, but so often this is done without at the same time considering how to coordinate engagement with employers and avoid multiple members of the institution contacting a single employer with little or no knowledge of each others actions. Having to work jointly through some of the perverse behaviours which might arise is not typically undertaken – and if this is not valued why wouldn't I keep focusing on my individual project?

Fear of conflict

It may seem contradictory to suggest that those at the top levels of HEIs fear conflict. For anyone used to the 'cut and thrust' of academic life this may seem a somewhat strange proposition. On reflection, however, most of the 'cutting and thrusting' which takes place is done somewhat indirectly. The articulate capacities of some senior colleagues can lead to some email correspondence becoming quite vicious. It is interesting to reflect whether the same vitriol one comes

across on these (rare) occasions would be so strongly held if done face to face. Anonymous peer reviewing of journal papers when done well can be highly challenging and helpful, done badly can be perceived as a personal attack on the integrity of the author. Another example where direct face to face engagement is not required. Even at major conference presentations, questioning and challenge can be done in a large group setting without direct engagement with the presenter.

In the context of a relatively small top team without a safe and secure set of 'ground rules' to guide the process of dealing with conflict over ideas many members would often rather resort to corridor conversations and political power play than have to confront the conflict through constructive dialogue. This unwillingness or inability to engage in creative conflict may also be linked to a lack of desire for collective action. It would appear that some team members would rather complain and/or undermine others after the event than sort things out at the beginning.

Absence of trust

The last dysfunction is the absence of trust. Lencioni suggests that to overcome this requires more of the following types of behaviours;

- Admitting weaknesses and mistakes
- Asking for help
- Accepting questions and input about their areas of responsibility
- Giving one another the benefit of the doubt before arriving at a negative conclusion
- Taking risks in offering feedback and assistance
- Appreciating and tapping into one another's skills and experiences
- Focusing time and energy on important issues, not politics
- Offering and accepting apologies without hesitation
- Looking forward to meetings and other opportunities to work as a group

Are these behaviours more prevalent in top teams in HEIs? Possibly - for a number of reasons. First, the nature of much of academic work is highly individualistic. By itself this need not lead to a lack of trust in team working but it may be a contributing factor. Add to this the limited degree to which formal feedback is part of the practice or culture of many parts of the higher education sector. Whilst changing, the process of providing individuals with feedback about their behaviour, how their behaviour may be limiting their effectiveness and how to influence and negotiate with others is somewhat less well developed than in other more corporate sectors. Historically we may also have a higher tendency to 'turn a blind eye' towards those who exhibit behaviours which are 'maverick' in nature. The consequence may be that we limit the willingness of others to challenge such individuals – and in so doing give recognition to such non-team behaviours.

2.2 Higher education sector literature

The amount of published work on TMTs in higher education is limited. In the USA, Bensimon & Neumann[20] provide the most comprehensive analysis based on several focused dialogues with 15 presidents of US HEIs. They report the difficulties of language (e.g. *'a 'team' is not always a team'*), and summarise the advantages and disadvantages of teamwork (see Table 3 opposite). They also highlight the importance of 'collaborative leadership' and the skills required to uncover the meaning that is embedded in the minds of fellow team members so as to develop a shared construction of meaning. They also offer some useful approaches to TMT 'self study' and outline a series of questions which may help TMTs to uncover their own life patterns and to understand why they exist in their current form and the implications of this for the future.

Gioia & Thomas[21] undertook an extensive study of how TMTs make sense of important issues that affect strategic change in modern academia. Using ethnographic-style interviews with members of a TMT during a period of major change they were able to identify three key roles undertaken by the TMT: 1) to make sense of the context faced by the institution; 2) to articulate the current perceptions of the institution and its aspirations for the future and; 3) to clarify the key strategic and political issues to be addressed.

In the UK, Jarzabkowski & Wilson[22] provide some interesting insights into how one TMT formulated and implemented strategy at the University of Warwick, and their article tracks the process of strategy formulation through the interplay of various structures within the institution. Their work also demonstrates the important role played by the TMT in balancing strong central direction and more devolved operational control mechanisms. In a later article by Jarzabkowski[23] the work is extended to three UK institutions (The University of Warwick, the London School of Economics and Oxford Brookes University), and the article explores some of the micro-practices of strategy. The article offers a framework of four interactive components from which strategy emerges, namely: 1) the collective structures

20 Bensimon & Neumann (1993)
21 Gioia & Thomas (1996)
22 Jarzabkowski & Wilson (2002)
23 Jarzabkowski (2003)

TABLE 3

THE ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES OF TEAM WORK (FROM BENSIMON AND NEUMANN, 1993)	
THE ADVANTAGES: 'PROMISES' OF TEAM WORK A TEAM:	THE DISADVANTAGES : 'HARD REALITIES' OF TEAM WORK A TEAM:
Can mean creative problem solving among diversely oriented minds	Can become isolated
Can facilitate cognitive complexity	May inadvertently fall into the trap of 'group think'
Can provide peer support	May actively silence different or opposing views
Can increase accountability	Is time consuming

of the organisation; 2) the primary actors within the TMT; 3) the practical activities in which they interact and; 4) strategic practices through which interaction is conducted.

Taylor[24] explores the relationship between the overall organisational structure and institutional leadership through a case study analysis of four UK institutions (all research based 'Russell Group' institutions) which have undergone major institutional level restructuring in recent years. The resulting challenges which have arisen for the TMT are identified and reflect, in particular, the importance of balancing the need for strong, authoritative central direction with a desire for devolved responsibilities.

The findings from the literature review outline some of the distinctions between TMTs in the corporate or business world with those found in higher education, and these differences are summarised below in Table 4.

TABLE 4

A COMPARATIVE PERSPECTIVE OF TMTS	
'CORPORATE' OR BUSINESS ORIENTED TMT	HIGHER EDUCATION TMT
Formal.	Relatively informal.
Explicit terms of reference.	More implicit terms of reference.
The single executive decision making body.	One of several executive level decision making bodies.
Small number of members.	Large variations in the number of members.
Clear membership.	Highly variable membership.
Involves non-executive members.	Non-executives are rarely present.
About strategic leadership but with a primary focus on the big strategic decisions, quarterly key performance indicators and a secondary focus on shaping the culture.	About strategic leadership, but often more about direction setting, resource allocation and setting the values with a secondary focus on taking big strategic decisions.
Well researched.	Very limited research exists.

24 Taylor (2006))

3 FRAMEWORKS AND PATTERNS

The desk research and literature review generated a series of hypotheses about particular types of organisational structures that might have implications for the constitution of top management teams in HEIs. Eight typical institutional groupings were identified for investigation through a series of interviews. These were chosen to represent a range of institutions across the sector, as follows;

1. Large 'pre-92 'college' based institutions
2. Large 'post-92' institutions with large academic unit structures
3. 'Ancient' university structures
4. Smaller recently established universities with a 'church' or faith dimension
5. Universities with multiple sites or 'distributed' campuses
6. Smaller research-focused institutions
7. Institutions with a significant international dimension
8. Private/not-for-profit/commercial higher education organisations

The desk research also helped to identify the relevant thematic areas related to TMTs which included.

- Composition - e.g. name, membership
- Role and function - e.g. rationale, terms of reference, responsibilities, accountability
- Processes - e.g. agenda setting, meeting format, dissemination of outcomes
- Relationships with other formal and informal bodies - e.g. senior management, governing body
- Development, support and succession planning – e.g. preparation of members for entry and exit
- Team effectiveness - e.g. teamwork, skills/personality/ experience mix
- Future trends and challenges - e.g. changing roles, composition, functions, and mode of operation

3.1 Conceptual frameworks

"The Executive has minutes and notes, takes papers, has decisions, but probably half of the meeting at least is devoted to discussions about issues with no papers. I mean, it's […] on the basis of ongoing operational issues, or exchanging of views on something which we all know about, but we may not have any papers on the table for, and people will have the opportunity to bring up anything that's concerning them towards the end of the meeting. So it's much less formal than the Academic Board would be, in that sense."

"What tends to happen is the boring things come up at the full meeting, like pensions and all that sort of stuff, and the more interesting things come up on a fortnightly basis…"

"[…] the informal ones take place in the HOIs office, around a round table, a bigger one than this, and the formal one takes place in one of our teaching rooms, around a big square table usually, it's quite interesting."

"[The TMT] it's a network, it's a network organisation. It's like a loose marketplace, the whole of the institution is about networking"

The type of TMTs found in the higher education sector reflect, to some extent, the degree to which those designing such teams believe 'team structure' to be a critical component of institutional leadership. Two, polarised, stereotypical views emerged in our analysis. These are summarised in Table 5 opposite.

Depending on the strength of the perspectives held by those involved in shaping a TMT, different designs emerge. Those of a more 'structured' view will tend towards a more planned, top down approach to the TMT structure, whilst those drawn more to a people-orientated perspective are more likely to focus on a more emergent, adaptive, bottom up view of team development. Whilst the more 'structured' view is more dominant, the 'people' perspective was also apparent in our case studies. Inevitably, the majority of people we met tended to share elements of both extremes – a desire (wish?) to locate the ideal structure, whilst also acknowledging that, given the highly individualistic nature of much work in higher education, that the influence of people and culture must be important variables.

To help describe the wide and varied nature of top teams three conceptual frameworks emerged from our analysis of our findings and from our first hand experience of different institutional settings. The first framework is a synthesis of the key functions of the top management team, and the second describes the alternative forms of top management team likely to be found in higher education institutions and the third a typology of TMT structures.

TABLE 5

STEREOTYPED PERSPECTIVES ON THE IMPORTANCE OF THE TMT IN THE HIGHER EDUCATION CONTEXT	
PEOPLE REALLY MATTER…	**STRUCTURES REALLY MATTER…**
Institutional leadership is probably a myth – and is certainly not found at 'the top'. Departmental leadership is what matters.	Institutional leadership is critical - and is enhanced by collective action at the top. 'Strong' leadership at the top is what matters.
The impact of the TMT on the institution is very difficult to assess, if anything they slow down the institution.	The work of the TMT has a major positive impact on the institution.
The workings of the TMT are rarely noticed and any consequences are of very limited effect.	The workings of the TMT have a major knock on effect on other teams across the university.
It makes no real difference how much planning you undertake, it's all about individuals and personalities.	Membership of the TMT needs to be very carefully planned to align roles and responsibilities to the institutional strategy.
Given the rapid changes in the sector, planning is futile, and as for development, fundamentally, it's about appointing good people, no amount of training and development can compensate.	The long term succession plan for the TMT requires action to help prepare and provide relevant training and development for current and future TMT members.
The notion of a single ideal TMT structure for an institution is crazy, frankly any 'structure' can be made to work given the right people and the right conditions.	With careful thought and analysis an ideal TMT structure exists for an institution – and this should rarely require major change.
Organisational culture is key	Organisational structure is key

FIGURE 2

POSSIBLE FUNCTIONS OF THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM

Strategic

1. Coordinating interactions with the Governing Board
2. Design of the Institution Resource Allocation Model
3. Decisions relating to areas of strategic investment and divestment
4. Recruitment and selection for key roles
5. Review and changes to organisational and committee structure

1. Horizon scanning and scenario planning
2. Direction setting
3. Creating and marketing sources of competitive advantage
4. Clarifying strategic position and determining high level priorities
5. Creating and coordinating links with key stakeholders

Internal ← **Integration Role** → **External**

1. Monitoring financial performance and redistributing resources
2. Monitoring implementation of the operational plan
3. Enhancing delivery by adapting/enhancing key business processes
4. Coordinating all significant change projects – capital and revenue related
5. Communication and engagement with all internal academic and professional service communities

1. Review of benchmark comparisons with peers and competitors
2. Managing relationships with significant funders, partners and clients
3. Promoting the institutions purpose to different market segments
4. Demonstrating the institutions role in its region and local community
5. Being a good 'corporate citizen' by acting ethically and with concern for the environment

Operational

3.1.1 Functions of the top management team

"some people rather cruelly call it the star chamber, but I don't know that that's entirely fair. It may not be fair to the star chamber . . . . . "

The matrix above (Figure 2) provides an example of how the different functions commonly ascribed to the TMT and/or the SMT could be allocated according to their particular focus, based on two dimensions: strategic-operational and internal-external. Although there may be some overlap between the dimensions, this framework proved to be a useful tool during the interviews to help understand the functional activities of both the TMT and the SMT. Most interviewees were able to place their own teams in one location within the matrix, although some teams were identified as having an integrative role and were active in all four quadrants.

3.1.2 Forms of the Top Management Team

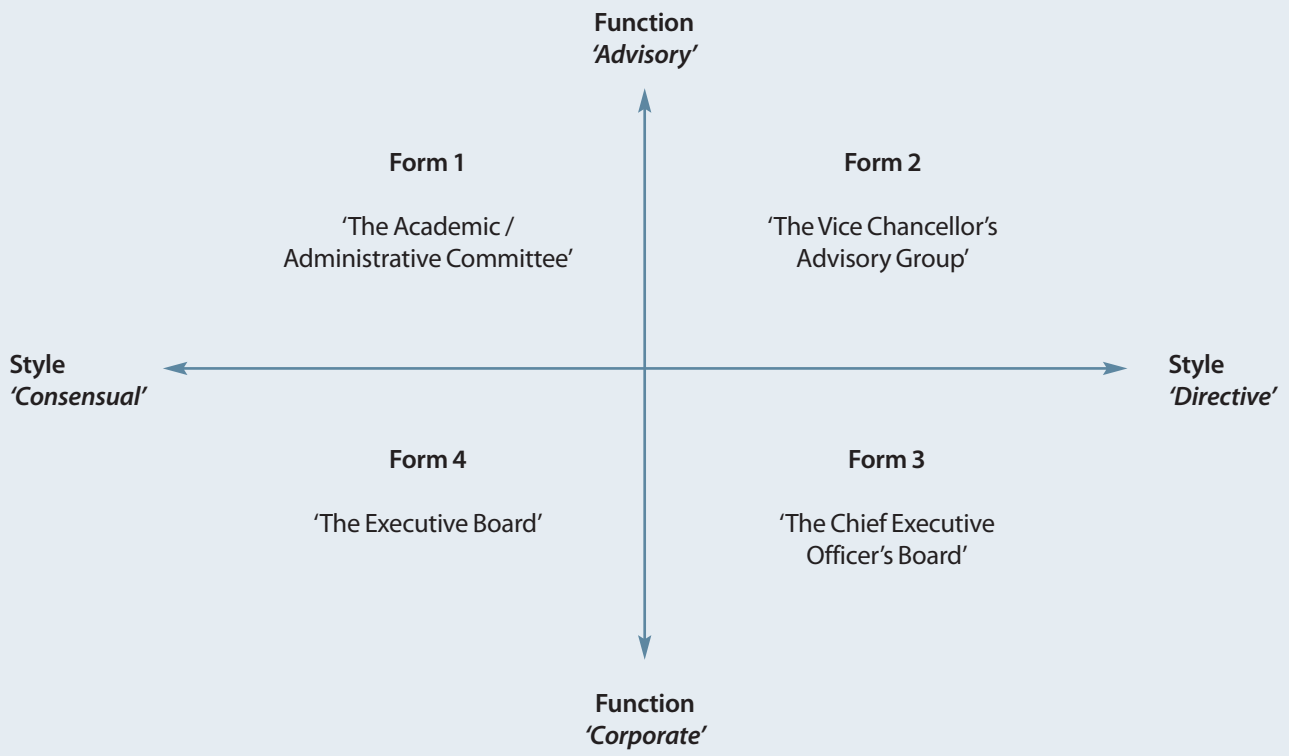
"The members of the Executive Committee are essentially advisors, constitutionally, to the vice-chancellor, although I think I cannot think of an instance recently in which the Vice Chancellor's gone against the strong feeling in the Executive Committee."

The second framework (Figure 3 overleaf) is a model which describes four different types of TMT in a matrix form, and provides examples of some different TMTs based on the dimensions of style and function. This matrix was inspired by the model of universities as organisations developed by McNay.[25]

25 McNay, I (1995)

FIGURE 3

POSSIBLE FORMS OF 'TOP MANAGEMENT TEAMS' IN HEIS



"Yes, yes. So [the top management team] has moved. I think we started in type three, as close as we can get. It gave itself the title corporate, it was much more directive, it was very kind of chief CEO led, in that way, and I think we've probably gravitated to type four, Executive Board"

From the analysis, it appears that all of these forms have validity within the sample institutions, although some seemed more suited to particular conditions (both internal and external). Table 6 overleaf outlines some of the positive and negative feature of the four example forms of TMT that are shown in Figure 3, and suggests the type of conditions that may suit each type.

It is also important to note at this point that identifying the TMT in some institutions is often difficult, since not all institutions have a formal TMT and the group (or indeed groups) that constitute(s) the 'top team' may in fact be highly informal and ad hoc. Furthermore, some institutions reported that they did not have a TMT, and that the wider senior management group undertook all of the functions of the TMT. This was more often the case in pre-1992 institutions.

TABLE 6

MATCHING FORMS OF TMT/SMT IN HEIS TO PARTICULAR CONDITIONS

	POSITIVE FEATURES	NEGATIVE FEATURES	SUITED TO ....
FORM 1 'The Academic / Administrative Committee' *(Advisory & Consensual)*	• High level of engagement with and to group decisions • Can fit with culture of some academic communities • Can help ensure a balanced representation is achieved from all major groups	• Speed of decision making is often slow • 'Group think' may occur in conditions where members have similar experience or have few 'external' members • Lack of clear lines of accountability for major decisions	• Conditions of stability in the external and / or internal environment situations where the HOI has considerable prior experience and high credibility as an academic leader
FORM 2 'The Vice Chancellor's Advisory Group' *(Advisory & Directive)*	As above plus • Increased speed of decision making where 'deadlock' or an impasse occurs	• Over reliance on 'the leader' to take key strategic decisions • Slow implementation of decisions may occur where time to consult has been too limited	• Conditions where speed of decision making may be critical (e.g. in a turnaround situation) • The HOI is new in post and needs to establish (or lose?) credibility quickly
FORM 3 'The Chief Executive Officer's Board' *(Corporate & Directive)*	• Speed of decision making • Increased level of cabinet responsibility for decisions	As in Form 2 plus • Danger of political blind spots if the HOI is over dominant	• Conditions where speedy and collective decision making matters (e.g. major business decisions requiring significant interdependence for successful implementation) • A new HOI with considerable prior experience
FORM 4 'The Executive Board' *(Corporate & Consensual)*	As in Form 3, plus • Increased commitment to implement decisions • Enhanced quality of decision making (if the right conditions are enabled)	As in Form 1, plus • The danger of potentially blurring the lines between governance and management functions	• Conditions where considered analysis of major strategic decisions is required • An experienced HOI is developing a high external profile and needs to empower the Board

3.2 A typology of TMT structures

The third conceptual framework we offer based on the findings from our interviews is to suggest that a typology of five alternative TMT structures exist in UK HEIs:

Structure 1: The Core TMT

"[….] the meeting always starts off with an update from the HOI of any particular issues that have happened in the last week, or will be happening in the next week. "

Such TMTs are small (4 to 6 members), very focused and exist as both formally constituted bodies (e.g. 'The Executive' or more commonly as a relatively informal grouping (e.g. the Monday Morning Meeting')

Structure 2: The Core (+) TMT

"It's a HOI advisory group, okay? So it's not formally in the structure and so we try to avoid the SMT has decreed or anything like that, so we make it clear it's advisory to the HOI, and because, you know, we have a vast number of committees, and it's important that things are properly channelled through them. "

These TMTs are larger (8 to 12 members) and extend beyond the Type 1 model to include a wider range of academic and professional service leaders. In some instances the additional members are 'invited' rather than permanent members of the TMT.

Structure 3: The Two Tier TMT

Such TMTs are often characterised by a relatively informal 'Core' TMT (as in Type 1) which meets regularly (weekly or bi-weekly) and a much enlarged 'Senior Management Group' (SMG) which may extend to 25 to 30 senior managers. The mode of interaction between the TMT and the SMG varies but is often achieved by periodic (between 3 and 6 months) 'management conferences' or other fora at which the two groups meet for discussion and exploratory review of strategic challenges. The larger group events are rarely viewed as decision making bodies.

Structure 4: The Representational TMT

Representational TMTs are evident in situations where the team structure requires a specific set of constituents to be represented on the TMT. The representation can take differing forms including:

- **Geographical representation** - e.g. where provosts of different campus locations in a distributed campus are represented, or where an institution has established separate entities for its 'home' and 'international' activities.
- **Federal representation** – e.g. in institutions which have a faith or multi-faith orientation, or contexts where the institution has evolved through merger with strong links continuing with the previously existing component bodies.
- **Business mix** representational model - where the Heads of very large academic units form the TMT (e.g. in those institutions which have given pre-eminent power to their large 'College' structures).
- **Role based representation** - where specific roles are perceived to be central to the TMT (e.g. the appointment of functional specialists to the TMT such as the Marketing or HR Director).

Structure 5: The Personality Based TMT

A personality based TMT occurs in circumstances where the TMT design is more oriented towards the individual rather than the team, where 'who' is on the team is given greater weight than the mutual complementarily of the team members. This is a more fluid model where the patronage of the HOI is much more significant in the selection and appointment process.

Other hybrid types also exist which reflect variations of the five structures identified above.

Table 7 overleaf summarises the characteristics of the alternative structures we have identified.

In this characterisation, and linking back to the stereotyped perspectives outlined in Table 5 (page 18), we believe those of a more 'structured' persuasion are more likely to be drawn towards structures 1 - 4, whereas those of a 'people' persuasion will tend to be more attracted towards structure 5. Again in reality we found many hybrids of these 'pure' models.

3.3 Role composition patterns within TMTs

"So CMG (Corporate Management Group) is a group which has, in terms of it's membership, in new speak, the vice-chancellor chairs, two pro-vice-chancellors in membership, and an assistant vice-chancellor, a recently introduced post, which will disappear again soon because the individual is leaving, the director of finance and planning, three deans, and my PA, as secretary to it, having got rid of the executive officer at some stage earlier on."

In reviewing different structures we also noted a range of different patterns in relation to the roles represented in TMTs across the sector. Overall, however, some broad

TABLE 7

COMMONLY OCCURRING TYPES OF TMTS IN HEIS

STRUCTURE	PRIMARY FOCUS OF ATTENTION		
	ACADEMICALLY FOCUSED	PROFESSIONAL SERVICES FOCUSED	BUSINESS FACING / COMMERCIALLY FOCUSED
1. CORE TMT • Formal • Informal	Small (4-6) fixed, core membership – majority have an academic role background. PVC's primarily at the top table.	Small (4-6) fixed, core membership – majority have a professional services role background.	Small (4-6) fixed, core membership – majority have a professional services and commercial role background.
2. CORE (+) TMT • Constant membership • Variable membership	Larger (8-10) group of senior staff – with majority having an academic role background (executive deans probably represented on the TMT)	Larger (8-10) group of senior staff – with majority having a professional service background (Finance, HR, Estates/Facilities probably represented on the TMT)	Larger (8-10) group of senior staff – with stronger emphasis on representation from strategic business units and business development, marketing, commercial service functions.
3. TWO-TIER TMT • Informal or Formal • Senior Management Group (SMG)	Emergence of a two tier structure – small core plus extended SMG which may extend to up to 30 people – emphasis on academic representation.	Emergence of a two tier structure – small core plus extended SMG which may extend to up to 30 people – emphasis on professional services representation.	Emergence of a two tier structure – small core plus extended SMG which may extend to up to 30 people – emphasis on business and commercial services representation.
4. REPRESENTANTIONAL TMT • Geographical focus • Federal focus	TMT membership determined by representation from across the institution, either as a consequence of a geographically distributed (multi-site) institution or as a consequence of a federal (multi-institution) structure. Emphasis on academic role representation.	TMT membership determined by representation from across the institution, either as a consequence of a geographically distributed (multi-site) institution or as a consequence of a federal (multi-institution) structure. Emphasis on professional service role representation.	TMT membership determined by representation from across the institution, either as a consequence of a geographically distributed (multi-site) institution or as a consequence of a federal (multi-institution) structure. Emphasis on business and commercial services role representation.
5. PERSONAL AND PERSONALITY BASED TMT	TMT membership primarily determined by 'personal credibility' – role definition much less important than ensuring institutional power balance. Secondary importance given to 'personal fit' with existing TMT members. Emphasis on academic role representation.	TMT membership primarily determined by 'personal credibility' – role definition much less important than ensuring institutional power balance. Secondary importance given to 'personal fit' with existing TMT members. Emphasis on professional service role representation.	TMT membership primarily determined by 'personal credibility' – role definition much less important than ensuring institutional power balance. Secondary importance given to 'personal fit' with existing TMT members. Emphasis on business and commercial services role representation.

patterns can be identified if one compares the functional roles to be found in the TMTs within institutions which can be considered as 'pre '92 institutions (extending to those in the Russell Group, the '94 group, etc.), compared to those which would judge themselves to be 'post 92' institutions (primarily 'new' universities).

3.3.1 Deputy-vice-chancellor/deputy principal

An important change in some institutions has been the deputy-vice-chancellor (or other similar title) role, with a move towards a more explicit US style 'provost' role emerging in part or in full. In some institutions the role is being accorded enhanced 'status', and as with some PVC roles, some DVC roles are becoming permanent rather than rotating. In other cases, some institutions senior managers are both DVCs and PVCs and thus take on similar responsibilities.

The scale of responsibilities of the DVC has also led, in some cases, to the establishment of several DVC roles. However, the distinction between the roles associated with such DVC positions are often very similar, if not identical, to those linked to the role of PVC in a different institution.

A further challenge occurring in some top management teams is that of resource allocation and management, particularly in cases where the role of DVC has become, or is becoming, more executive in nature. The impact of this change is to create challenges to the way in which the traditional academic planning functions, controlled by the DVC are integrated with the administrative support functions which in pre '92 institutions are controlled by the registrar. There is a trend in both the pre and post '92 institutions for PVCs to have control over more resources and for DVCs to have their own staff. This changes the power balance away from the registrar and in some instances challenges the lines of authority normally found in a traditional unitary model for the provision of professional services.

3.3.2 Pro-vice-chancellors/vice-principals

> *"[…] we also have pro-vice-chancellors (PVCs). The PVCs are totally different from those at other universities, in that they don't necessarily have a management function, it's a title given for excellent work over many years. So we award the title of pro-vice-chancellor periodically. For example, our [……] is a pro-vice-chancellor. [….] it's part of our reward structure. We view this as very, very important, that they're not just academics, because in this university you succeed on merit, not because you're - well, I hope, some particular role, and it would be most annoying if non-academics felt there were things they could not achieve"*

Smith et al[26] explored the changing nature of the PVC in a separate research project funded by the Leadership Foundation for Higher Education. However, in some pre '92 institutions there is a move away from cross-institutional to territorial portfolios, whilst in a number of post '92 institutions we have noted a move toward the PVC acting as a professional manager (line manager/project manager) with responsibilities for specific Faculties or areas of professional services.

In some of the larger pre'92 institutions there is some evidence of a growth in the number of fractional PVCs (undertaking the role for a part of their time, ranging from 0.2 to 0.8 FTE). Normally, however, such peripatetic PVCs are not usually part of the core TMT.

3.3.3 Registrar (and Secretary)

The registrar role is also undergoing change, with a move towards either a greater emphasis in a unitary system on the role as chief operating officer (COO) or a move towards a binary (or dispersed) system with increasing numbers of other senior officers reporting directly to the HOI or the DVC, rather than through the unitary registrar. In such cases there may be an academic registrar and secretary and a director of corporate services for example.

3.3.4 Professional service roles

The impact and recognition of the value of strategic level professional service functions is creating new challenges to top management teams, particular in cases where PVCs also have cross-institutional responsibility for one or more of these areas of activity. The finance director is becoming an increasingly strategic role in the top management team and the HR and marketing directors are also becoming much more influential and having more strategic influence within the top management team than has historically been the case, particularly in the pre'92 sector. In addition, other professional roles such as the director of IT/library/information systems, the knowledge management director and the research and business director are also increasing in prominence.

3.3.5 The dean

> *"[…] although that's still the core team, there's always one of our Deans invited there as an observer, and it's pretty normal now for one or other of the Heads of Service to be there for part of the meeting, depending on what the subjects on the agenda are. So it's a much more kind of open style of management and leadership, although actual membership has remained exactly the same."*

26 Smith et al (2007)

"One of the dangers when you have schools, or even worse, when you've got departments, you get a very narrow self interest, and I've heard some universities described as a kind of federation of robber barons. Because part of the Deans' role, admittedly a minority of it, is cross institutional. I think that actually makes them, from my point of view, better citizens, in the sense that they realise if they're going to succeed, it can't be at the cost of another school, it's got to be a positive sum gain, not a zero sum, and certainly not a negative sum."

"One of the arguments where you've got a permanent senior management team is it tends to be strong on management. There's nothing quite as chastening as realising, and I've been a dean with senior responsibilities at a university, and you know that come three or four years time you'll be back there, so be pleasant on the way up, because you'll want people to be pleasant to you when you're on the way down."

Another role which has been undergoing significant change in recent years has been that of dean. Historical differences have existed in the pre- and post '92 institutions in relation to the role of dean. In the pre '92 institutions, the role was largely representational, and typically on a fixed term appointment (normally 3-5 years) with resources devolved to the departmental level. In many cases the role was also 'rotational' in nature, with a head of department expected to take on this additional responsibility. Appointment to the role would rarely be openly advertised outside the institution, and in some instances may not have been advertised internally. A degree of patronage existed in the appointment process, or where patronage (by the HOI was not evident) a 'buggins turn' model often existed where through consensual decision making a view was reached by the relevant heads of department as to who should take on the role for the forthcoming period.

A different model typically existed in the post '92 sector, with the role of dean being a permanent executive role. In both categories the dean was not usually a member of the inner top management team, although generally he/she would be a member of the wider senior management group.

Over the past 5 years the roles in both categories have been undergoing some change.

In the pre '92 group of institutions there has been a move towards appointments which are:

- more transparent and open to applicants external to the institution
- are on a more permanent basis (albeit many remain fixed term in nature), and
- are more 'executive' in nature with increased levels of devolved budget accountability

In the post '92 group of institutions, the changes would appear to have been less dramatic. A pattern which does appear to be discernible is in extending the role of dean to include some element of cross-institutional responsibility. This has led to some combined roles of dean and PVC, or new roles of as Associate/Assistant PVC either in combination with, or separate from the role of dean of faculty. The move towards increasing levels of devolved budget accountability also appears to be a trend in this group of institutions.

In both types of institutional setting the extent to which the deans form part of the inner top management team or are part of the wider senior management group seems to be one of the most common organisational design dilemmas facing the HOI. Arguments for and against inclusion seem to be equally well-balanced.

Arguments in favour of including deans ranged from

- Increasing recognition of the vital role they play as conduits for senior level policy
- The need for deans to be involved from the earliest stages in policy formulation
- The need to strengthen the voice of the academy at the top table

Arguments against the inclusion ranged from

- The difficulties of inclusion creating too large a 'top team'
- In situations where deans are primarily representational that they are not sufficiently strategic roles
- In situations where they report to more executive PVC's that their inclusion is unnecessary

However, on balance, the pattern is increasingly towards inclusion as the role has become much more executive in nature.

3.3.6 New roles in the top and senior management teams

"We've just introduced a Project Office, actually, for managing, for providing information on all our ongoing projects, just as you might have in a big company, and they're just getting themselves going now. They're really starting off with all of the obvious infrastructure projects, Estates and IT, but they will move beyond that, to a certain extent, and there will be a debate about how far they need

to move, and this is to get better management of our projects, so we know how much we're really spending on things, and how far committed we are on things."

A further emergent trend across a number of institutions is the establishment of new senior management level roles that have different levels of influence on top management. These vary in scope and duration. Some are often wide ranging in their scope (e.g. adviser to the vice-chancellor), whereas others (e.g. pro-provost or pro-vice-provost) typically have a more limited set of responsibilities (e.g. linked to new areas of growing importance) based on functional specialisms.

In some post '92 institutions new 'assistant-vice-chancellor (AVC)' and 'APVC' or 'ADVC' type roles are emerging – often with a very specific 'project based' brief for significant institutional projects. These are often seen as 'testing' ground prior to appointment to a full PVC portfolio. Other emerging roles in the professional services area in addition to those already referred to in section 3.3.4 include: director of strategic/international/business partnerships; director of projects or programme manager; and campus provost (where a distributed campus model exists).

Table 8 below provides a summary of the patterns which seem to be emerging in both parts of the sector.

TABLE 8

SUMMARY OF COMMONLY OCCURRING ROLE PATTERNS FOUND IN TMTS

STRUCTURE	TYPE OF INSTITUTION	
	PRE-92 INSTITUTIONS	POST-92 INSTITUTIONS
1. CORE TMT • Formal • Informal	**Size:** Small (4-6) fixed, core membership. **Roles Represented** Typically comprising • the HOI • registrar/secretary • 3 PVC's typically with cross-institutional portfolios e.g. research, teaching and learning/education, external relations, international, etc.) **Trends and Emerging Patterns** 1. Finance director increasingly represented in core TMT with the registrar/secretary – even where unitary structures remain in place. 2. Some evidence of a move towards a permanent career role as deputy HOI in cases where the HOI has a significant external/fundraising role. Typically Deputy has a brief for resource management. 3. Move towards longer periods of tenure at PVC level – from 2/3 years to 4/5 years. 4. Move towards appointment to PVC role/TMT at a younger age. 5. Relatively limited evidence of other professional service directors as full members of the TMT. Where evidenced typically HR, development, IS/IT and Marketing. 6. Some evidence in institutions where large academic units (e.g. colleges) have been created of representation of full time 'executive deans/heads of colleges' onthe TMT.	**Size:** Small (4-6) fixed, core membership. **Roles Represented** Typically comprising of • the HOI • finance director • 3 D/PVC's typically with resources and other cross-institutional portfolios e.g. research, teaching and learning /education, external relations, international, etc.) **Trends and Emerging Patterns** 1. Finance director without exception always a full member of the TMT. 2. Deputy HOI role varies in authority over resources – from full control to very limited control. 3. Use of the deputy HOI title as well as PVC title may or may not signal any greater level of seniority for deputy. 4. PVC roles generally full time career roles with specific portfolios – some evidence of a move towards more frequent changes in portfolios (every 18 months-2 years). 5. Trend to inclusion of HR in the TMT where HR viewed as a strategic function. More common in post '92 than in pre'92 institutions. 6. Again where larger 'Super Faculties' have been established, executive deans likely to be represented as full time members of the TMT.

TABLE 8

SUMMARY OF COMMONLY OCCURRING ROLE PATTERNS FOUND IN TMTS (CONTINUED)

STRUCTURE	TYPE OF INSTITUTION	
	PRE-92 INSTITUTIONS	POST-92 INSTITUTIONS
2. CORE (+) TMT • Constant membership • Variable membership	**Size:** Larger (8-10) group of senior staff. **Roles Represented** Typically comprising • the HOI • registrar/secretary • 3-6 PVC's with cross-institutional portfolios e.g. research, teaching and learning/education, external relations, international, etc.; PVC/deans (provosts in some institutions) with faculty roles • professional services representation extended to include registrar/secretary and finance • representation from HR, Estates, Planning, IS/IT, International, Development and other units on an 'as required' basis. **Trends and Emerging Patterns** 1. Finance director role growing in importance with a separation between the 'Strategic FD' and the 'Operational FD' in a limited number of cases. 2. Some limited evidence of tensions emerging between the role of deputy HOI and registrar roles where deputy has more direct accountability for resources. 3. Some evidence in larger institutions of additional (part-time) PVC roles for specialist areas of activity (e.g. partnerships, staff development, etc.) 4. Some limited evidence of the separate role of university secretary becoming more of a legal services unit and less frequently represented as a full member of the Core (+) TMT. 5. Some limited evidence of the use of more professional central professional services roles (executive assistants) to assist with the coordination of the work of the 'Office of the VC'.	**Size:** Larger (8-10) group of senior staff. **Roles Represented** Typically comprising • the HOI • finance director • 3 D/PVC's typically with resources and other cross-institutional portfolios e.g. research, teaching and learning/education, external relations, international, etc. • deans likely to be full time members where faculty/school structure is limited to around 4-6 Units. • professional services likely to be further represented by the HR function (again where perceived as strategic) • may also involve other functions such as Estates, Planning, IS/IT, International, Development among others on an 'as required' basis. **Trends and Emerging Patterns** 1. Finance director role gaining wider remit for commercial activities of the institution – and in some instances extending to encompass Estates. 2. Some limited evidence of the use of additional cross institutional roles such as assistant VC/PVC with a focus on project working. 3. Some evidence of additional professional central professional service roles (executive assistants) to assist with the coordination of the work of the 'Office of the VC'.

4 ISSUES AND GUIDELINES TO INFORM ACTION

The following guidelines are intended to provide the 'architects' of top teams with some guidance on which to reflect and provide a framework on which to build their new structure. By highlighting the issues which have emerged from research findings and consulting experience we hope that any unintended effects of incorrectly handled 'restructuring' can be limited or avoided. We also hope that well intentioned and necessary change can be implemented in an even more effective way.

Each of the guidelines on its own provides only one component of a larger jigsaw, the weight and importance of each varying according to the context. Considering one or a sample of the issues we have identified will be of some value. We would, however, encourage our architects to reflect on all of the issues that we outline below. A slightly weak foundation in one area may often cause cracks to appear throughout the edifice. We would strongly recommend a more holistic review involving all 16 guidelines.

Our guidelines start by focusing on 'the what' of top team working (motives, roles, and functions) before moving on to 'the how' of team working (alignment of agendas, team roles, communication and other process issues).

4.1 Guideline 1: Rationale and motive(s)

> *"….the advent of more and more market aspects to education, the growth of the customer, I think is very important in getting the mindsets attuned to that environment, the third arm activities interrelating with industry and commerce, how we sell our products into those markets, how we maintain hopefully, some of the benefits of being still a collegial organisation, as an academic community. So I see that as some of the challenges, being publicly funded, but also having to have business models driving more and more of what we're about these days. So I think those are the kind of challenges over the next few years, that will still be underlining the local, more local manifestations, plus, I mean, the international agenda, yes, it's a big part of that as well."*

The complexity of the challenges and contexts within which HEIs operate suggests that some simple, 'easy to import' solution to resolving a perceived need to change the TMT is unlikely to be effective. And yet, this is quite a common approach used in HEIs. How frequently has it occurred that a new structure is introduced (institutionally and in the TMT) which bears a striking resemblance to the one which existed in the institution from which the new leader has been recruited? Sometimes this is the right response – such as when the context and the challenges are very similar – although in other situations it can be inappropriate and not justified.

Whatever the apparent driver of change (e.g. the appointment of a new HOI, promotion within the team, retirement from the team, a performance issue, or whim!) a dispassionate evaluation of the motives of the person or persons initiating change in the TMT is a key starting point. Before making any change it can be helpful to take stock and understand why the TMT structure is as it is? Too speedy a decision to change a TMT can lead to significant long term damage, often because the rationale for the pre-existing structure had not been fully recognised. History often repeats itself in this territory as in others, so taking time to talk to those involved and those who have a longer history in the institution before necessarily reaching the conclusion that significant change is required can pay dividends. Is 'it' really badly broken? Or does 'it' simply need some care and attention? If the former, a clear articulation of what is badly broken is an important first step, and it is important to understand whether your perception either as a team member or as the HOI is widely shared by others?

So why restructure? What could be the rationale for change? Some common rationales we would highlight include; a desire to

- Enhance institutional performance in some area which is not being represented adequately at the top table (e.g. research, third stream activities, international work etc.)
- 'Refresh' the top team through introducing people who will bring new ideas or perspectives (e.g. perhaps with experience from outside higher education)
- Change the power dynamics within the top team (e.g. the balance of academic vs. professional service representation)
- Reduce or dilute the influence or perceived power of key individuals or 'barons' (e.g. an overly powerful registrar or executive dean?)
- Enhance the status of some new or increasingly important areas of activity which is particularly critical to the institutions future (e.g. Human Resources, Marketing, Development, Fundraising, Partnerships, etc.).

It is important to note that these rationales are not necessarily mutually exclusive, and more than one may be an important driver for change.

The rationales described are largely positively framed. However, it is clear that restructuring also occurs for negative reasons, e.g. to avoid dealing with a performance issue or because a HOI may feel threatened by one or more individuals who are either seeking to limit his/her influence or in extremis wish him/her to be displaced?

> *"So I have shifted the line management around at various stages, partly to broaden the experience of the Pro Vice Chancellors, who might be aspirant heads of institution anyway, so I think one should always try to broaden experience for that reason, but also because I think you get slightly unholy alliances built up between heads of support departments and if you like, the people who are perceived as their sponsors within the [.. . . .] So, I think, for example, our [……..], who is extremely good, had managed to get one of my PVCs entirely wrapped around her little finger, and it would be not at all a bad thing to shift the line management to the other one, and not resisted by anyone actually, it's a sort of new and interesting experience for everybody."*

The top team may also be restructured in response to a perceived need for the HOI role to be reoriented or re-balanced, either in response to a changing set of expectations from the institution, or alternatively it could also be for more personal reasons, to assist the individual with their own career development. This issue is expanded in more detail below.

It is likely, more often than not, that the motives for restructuring will be implicit and not directly articulated. Indeed in some cases it may be unwise for them to be stated too explicitly. However, without a clear exploration of the motives and rationales for change the subsequent thinking and actions may be less than effective.

Therefore, guideline 1 for our team architects is to consider the value of reflecting on their real motives for wishing to change. Given the highly sensitive nature of this issue, the value of exploring this highly personal and 'un-discussable' issue with someone external to the institution may well prove beneficial.

4.2 Guideline 2: Role(s) and role expectations

> *"I'm sure it's true with every institution, that there are things that a head of institution is good at, and there are things that they either aren't good at, or couldn't care less about, and so the patterns on how tasks get distributed are going to vary accordingly."*

The second 'what' factor we identified is that of the 'role expectations' for the TMT, which highlights the need to address the following questions:

- What are the collective demands expected of the TMT?
- Which of these are of highest priority?
- How well are these currently fulfilled?
- Where might there exist gaps which are in need of being filled?

To aid the process of clarifying and negotiating the role expectations for the TMT, Table 9 opposite identifies 20 potential expectations of TMTs.

While all these expectations place important demands on TMTs, their relative importance will vary over time. Identifying and clarifying these will be particularly significant before undertaking significant structural change in the top team.

For example, Table 9 could be used to help collectively assess the perceptions of the current TMT members (e.g. What is our collective perception of the relative priorities over the next 1-2 years?). In addition, this may lead to considering further 'task' related questions such as;

- What institutional strategic priorities, processes and projects will require most leadership?
- What skills and capabilities will be of most value in responding to these priorities, processes and projects?
- Which delegated responsibilities (as identified above) need to be led by others in the absence of a member of the TMT, and who should be given this responsibility?

Other questions relating to the wider team balance may also benefit from consideration, questions such as;

- How can we ensure an appropriate balance of experience, political representation and ability across the team?
- How can we ensure continuity in the role expectations of the TMT whilst also updating and refreshing the membership?
- How will the personalities, modes of working and preferred leadership styles align and operate collectively?

Our second guideline for architects is to encourage them to reflect on, and identify, the critical expectations of the TMT for the future. This should also assist in identifying the range of other capacities needed during the period within which the new top team will be operating. The process can be further refined by inviting others to judge those which are most significant (e.g. the chair of council / governors?)

TABLE 9

COLLECTIVE ROLE EXPECTATIONS OF TMT MEMBERS IN HEIS

ROLE EXPECTATION	ILLUSTRATIVE ROLE EXPECTATIONS?	PRIORITY?
1. Institutional strategy	Facilitators of the process of institutional and cross institutional strategy development & planning.	
2. Financial custodian	Ensuring financial oversight and ultimate accountability to funders, donors and customers for the appropriate use of public funds.	
3. Leadership of academic mission & vision	Providing adequate focus and articulation of the academic mission and vision of the institution.	
4. Implementation of policy	Ensuring the delivery of agreed higher education/ government and other policies at a national, regional and more local level.	
5. Change architects	Delivery of the institutional changes necessary to ensure the timely and efficient delivery of the agreed strategic plan.	
6. Chairing	Chairing and leading the most senior executive and academic decision making bodies in the institution.	
7. Resource allocation	Ensuring resources are allocated to institutional priorities in a timely, fair and effective manner.	
8. Custodian of reputation	Retaining and enhancing the reputation of the institution, through standard setting and quality processes.	
9. Risk management	Identifying institutional risks and pro-actively creating processes which ensure that any potential impact is minimised.	
10. Internal communications	Being personally visible and designing processes which lead to timely communication of critical issues, and which allow for routine and open feedback.	
11. Media presence	Publicly representing the institution in the local, national and international media either at times of crisis or to actively promote the institution.	
12. Policy influence and lobbying	Influencing and shaping policy – locally, regionally, nationally, internationally.	
13. Ambassadors	Being the public face of the institution, visible externally and engaging actively with stakeholders critical to the institution's future success.	
14. Brand and image makers	Supporting and developing the external image of the institution, ensuring this suitably reflects the institutional reality.	
15. Enterprise and business development	Actively engaging in promoting the commercial and translational outputs from the institution and in winning new business.	
16. Fundraising	Engaging alumni and other sponsors as sources of new funding.	
17. Talent spotters and developers	Identifying and attracting new talent whilst also developing and recognising internal talent.	
18. Governance link	Building strong and influential relationships with the governing body and ensuring the effective delivery of timely information.	
19. Non-executives	Contributing to the development of other organisations relevant to the activities of the institution.	
20. Other…		

Completion of this aspect of the 'foundations' for the TMT will help clarify the skills and capabilities needed for the future as well as identifying any gaps which might exist. Once this has been completed, Top Team architects can begin to focus on the characteristics of team members.

4.3 Guideline 3: Purpose – clarify areas of decision making & time management

There is a commonly held assumption (highlighted by Katzenbach[27]) that within a TMT 'team working is always required'. In common with the earlier cited work we also found this to be the case in the TMTs we reviewed.

The most prevalent style of operating in TMTs is generally one of individual, rather than collective or mutual, accountability. More successful TMTs tend to have a capacity to recognise the key issues on which decisions must be reached through effective team working and then ensure that the TMT focuses its energy on these vital issues. For the remainder of its time together 'teamwork' in the TMT is usually focused on sharing information about each other's individual areas of responsibility, supplemented by bilateral and trilateral discussions and negotiations with other members of the TMT. To define the collective purpose of the TMT it is necessary to identify those issues and areas of decision making on which the TMT must act with the full discipline of teamworking. This requires answering questions such as;

- What are the critical institutional priorities which can only be achieved through integrated and collective action?
- On what issues does the TMT recognise that mutual rather than individual accountability is crucial?

It is also crucially important for the TMT to decide on which topics it spends its valuable time. For example there is a need for the TMTs agenda to focus on the right mix of strategic and more operational matters. This will be influenced by the agenda setting process and questions such as:

- Who actually determines the agenda?
- Is it set by the right people or inappropriately delegated?
- Is there effective alignment between the agenda for the TMT and the agenda meetings of the wider senior management group and the Governing Body, or are these disconnected and fragmented?

If the process is somewhat ad hoc, with inadequate time allocated for debate, then the quality of leadership delivered by the team is likely to be inadequate.

Our third guideline is to ensure open and transparent debate takes place to identify those issues on which it is crucial that the TMT operate as a team and to ensure that adequate time is being devoted to these issues.

4.4 Guideline 4: Succession management

> *"I notice one of your questions is about selection, preparation and succession planning. Huge problem, huge, huge problem. Nobody wants to do management roles"*

> *"[…] I mostly have a view that although each University is an independent employer, technically, career development and succession planning are best not thought of in terms of the individual institution. It's almost inconceivable that any members of the staff of an institution, academic or otherwise, could make a full and successful career progression without leaving institutions, either because the opportunities will never be there at the right time within their own institutions, and particularly in a small one like this, or because, or and because they really need the experience of having [experience]in a variety of different places. So I'm constantly encouraging staff to move."*

Strongly connected to the issue of role and role expectations, with its focus on the future needs of the institution, is the matter of succession planning (now increasingly referred to as succession management). This has always been a/or the key concern for top team architects.

- Where will the next PVC come from? Internally or increasingly externally?
- How can we support X to gain a promoted post (usually elsewhere)?
- What on earth, are we going to do with Y when her fixed term as PVC ends (particularly since she is so good)?
- Have we got an adequate pool of potential candidates for those in head of department / school positions?
- How many headhunters do we know? How many contact us? And so on….

Our research indicates that a more explicit and structured approach to succession into, and exit, from the TMT is becoming a much more significant issue for many HEIs.

Despite this perception, relatively few institutions reported that they had explicit succession plans or development related to the top team, although there was agreement that it is an increasingly pressing concern given the need to

27 Katzenbach (1998)

maintain an effective top team. 'succession planning' appears to be much more of an emergent process.

At the more structured end of the spectrum, succession planning could involve clearly identifying a range of potential candidates who may become members of the TMT, providing structured development opportunities (e.g. leading on significant change projects) together with access to relevant external executive education and training programmes followed by a period shadowing the existing role holder. At the other extreme it is still the case that many members of the TMT find themselves appointed to their new roles with little preparation and induction into the role, or any ongoing support (e.g. leadership development or coaching).

In those institutions with a fixed term arrangement for deans and/or pro-vice-chancellors, transition planning from the TMT is a particularly important issue. Returning to becoming a productive senior academic may be relatively straightforward for some, but for many the transition process is often problematic, even with the help of a period of sabbatical leave. Indeed, a difficult exit from the TMT may result in an individual ultimately leaving the institution and taking their skills and experience elsewhere.

> *"Your preparation for exit from the team was an interesting one, because our dean of [……] retired and went back to research in his department, and I know he misses being dean, I know he does. I don't suppose he misses necessarily SMT meetings, he just misses being a dean, and so we'd not prepared him for that […..] I see him from time to time, he tells me about all these trips he's doing, and I'm saying it's wonderful, how lucky you are, and he gives me a very baleful look."*

The role of developmental programmes such as those provided by the Leadership Foundation and others as part of succession planning is becoming much more common. For example, let us consider the Top Management Programme (TMP) for illustrative purposes. Now in its ninth year of operation (current cohort TMP 15), with over 250 alumni, a discernible pattern is apparent in the way a number of institutions have used the TMP as a central element of their developmental support for those moving into the TMT. Institutions from across the sector, such as Queen Mary, Goldsmiths, Liverpool John Moores, Lincoln, Stirling, Edinburgh, Cardiff, Nottingham, among others have supported 5 or 6 members of their TMT through the TMP as they transition towards membership of the TMT, or during their early tenure. Similar patterns may begin to appear for programmes at other levels over time. What is clear is that planning has been taking place to assist with the process of transition from senior management to the top management team.

> *"[…] .there's induction and training, and we do encourage attendance on the top team, TMP. I went on TMP1 and gradually everybody's been on TMP. [….] So four of us have now been on TMP, the new director of corporate services has only been with us since last June, or something, June or July, and he hasn't been on it. The vice-chancellor hasn't been on it, but he's been on things in the past."*

While the subject of succession requires considerably more attention than we can accommodate in the report, there is little significant evidence to suggest it will demand less time of a top team architect than in the past. Munro[28] provides a wealth of material on this topic which any team architect could benefit from reading.

Guideline 4 therefore is a reminder to top team architects of the importance of more frequent, more systematic and more collective time devoted to succession issues. Succession issues should be discussed on an annual basis by the TMT. Furthermore the conceptual thinking needs to move on from the somewhat limited (albeit of some value) replacement planning approach to a much more strategic conceptualisation focused on a balance between institutional, team and individual needs.

4.5 Guidelines 5-6: Career transitions

The fourth of our 'what?' aspects of top team working involves taking stock of where all members of the TMT (including the HOI) are on their career journey. A dispassionate review of the career trajectories and the career transition points they are all facing in the period when the new top team is in place is a further issue worthy of consideration. First we suggest that the HOI should take stock of their personal career point before then assessing where each member of the current TMT is in relation to their career.

4.5.1 Career transitions for the HOI

In an earlier paper[29] the career transition points facing a HOI were described. His 'Seven Ages' framework offers an interesting metaphor for the potential career transitions which the modern HOI/VC/principal might face in his or her career. It is interesting to note that Breakwell's study of VC's career patterns[30] also highlights the issue of 'career stages' for VC's.

28 Munro (2006)
29 Kennie (2006)
30 Breakwell (2008)

Stage 1: The Honeymoon Principal

Unless the HOI has been appointed in a period of major crisis, the first 3-6 months is a period for listening and taking soundings on the tentative plans for the future. Whilst the new principal/VC will have clearly demonstrated their academic credibility and capacity to lead part of an institution or function, the move to the top job requires the building of credibility as a strategic leader. To do so requires careful political and managerial skills. It is also a time to 'take stock' of the existing top team. The honeymoon can extend longer but rarely does it extend beyond 12 months.

Stage 2: The 'Positively Pushy Principal', or the Negatively 'Pushed Around' Principal

Stage 2 is typically associated with the transition from the honeymoon period to 'mid-term', (around 18 months in role). By the end of the honeymoon period the expectation will grow that the HOI is ready to take action to deal with those issues requiring most attention. To progress through this stage demands an ability to balance the need for delivering on the operational requirements of the institution (perhaps, short term efficiency measures), whilst also having a growing sense of strategic positioning for the institution (in terms of longer term effectiveness measures). The HOI will also have had time to develop coalitions to help influence those who may be resistant to their plans or who may be actively working against the agreed strategy. High level influencing skills will be critical at this stage and will ultimately determine how this stage is viewed by others. It is also a time when the HOI will be heavily reliant on the top team they have developed. It is also the stage when the HOI will know more accurately what kind of TMT is required in the medium term – who and in what roles.

Stage 3: The 'Chief Executive' Principal

Stage 3 may start as early as the end of the first year in office for a new HOI, and may well be increasingly important after the second year. By this stage most HOI's will have a good overview of all of the functions for which they have responsibility, and if they are perceived to be 'doing a good job' will have 'earned their spurs' by delivering real value to the institution. They will also have established themselves as the leader of the TMT. They will also have developed an effective relationship with the chair of the governing body. By this stage they will also, hopefully, have gained sufficient respect to justify the chief executive element of the role. This is an important transition through which some fail to progress. The early warning signs that a HOI is failing to make this transition comes in a number of forms: for example, they begin to exhibit characteristics associated with particular caricatures

- The Pampered Principal, or
- The Perpetually Politically Paranoid Principal, or
- The Poorly Prepared Principal.

The caricatures suggest why the HOI might be failing. In the first, the sign to watch out for is an excessive focus on unnecessary and/or costly ways of operating. This is where judgement is being tested. In the second, the HOI lacks 'political savvy' or 'guile' and this begins to limit their effectiveness. Finally, in the third case, the HOI begins to fully appreciate the true nature of the role they have accepted. They begin to 'regress' back to the familiar (and enjoyable) aspects of their role, avoiding more demanding or challenging aspects. Sometimes this is not noticed for some time as others cover for the lack of coordination which is required – but ultimately this will lead to their failure in the role.

Stage 4: The 'Progressive' Principal

If the average tenure of a HOI in office is now of the order of 6 to 7 years, stage 4 begins around half way through this first term. If the transition to chief executive has been successful, this is the period when some real change can take place. Progressive strides can be taken to move the institution strategically in the right direction. Ambitious agendas which under other circumstances would not be considered can now be pursued; mergers, major re-structuring, major investment decisions are all options which might be on the agenda.

Alternatively, one might see signs of the 'Paradoxical or Perplexed Principal'. Self doubt begins to grow. The 'alternative' work which began to develop in stage 3 has by now become more significant. The HOI is unclear in which direction they want their career to progress. On the one hand they have committed primarily to a management career, although much of what they are doing is quite the opposite. If a good deputy VC/principal is willing to provide cover, a potential face saving way forward might exist. On the other hand, if such a saviour does not appear then this can be a dangerous and destabilising period for the HOI and the institution. Decisions are avoided, a lack of focus occurs and good senior staff begin to leave this institution.

Stage 5: The 'Serial' Principal, or the 'Reinvented' Principal

Stage 5 is typically around the period from 5 to 7 years in role. It is time for different decisions. Does the HOI commit to a long term role in this institution and recognise they will need to 'reinvent' themselves? Or alternatively, do they

move onto a bigger or more challenging context and take their experience and skills to another organisation? (i.e. the 'Serial' outcome) or do they stand down and move towards other options? This is a challenging period and requires serious self reflection and honest appraisal of the pros and cons of the various alternatives. Without this one might see the beginning of further 'displacement' activities leading to the 'Protective' Principal, and/or the 'Property' Principal. The protective response may be a reaction to a growing disquiet across the institution about the lack of delivery or credibility of the HOI. To protect him or herself, a growing siege mentality begins to be apparent, emotional outbursts and a loss of perspective occurring more frequently. Evidence of the property response is a growing interest in iconic buildings, for example.

Stage 6: The 'Portfolio' Principal, and/or the 'Positively Powerful' Principal

For those who genuinely 'reinvent' themselves or move onto bigger or different challenges stage 6 can be a productive time. By this time the capacity to lead and manage an institution is well developed and the value and personal need for a greater external focus can lead to a growing 'portfolio' approach. The portfolio might involve working as a non-executive director elsewhere, involvement in a new international venture or involvement with a national body. Alternatively, with a new or reinvented vision, a serious second term in office with a new agenda for change can develop.

With luck, those who rise to these challenges can look forward to being remembered as major figures who transformed their institutions. If unlucky they might find themselves facing the bleak reality of being remembered as one of those who lived through Stage 7.

Stage 7: The 'Preoccupied and Publicist' Principal, and/or the 'Procrastinating' Principal, and/or the 'Pompous and Precious' Principal, leading to the 'Pastiche' Principal

This is sadly a very unfortunate stage of transition. As the caricatures imply this can either be a period as a somewhat egotistical self-publicist, a period avoiding difficult decisions (the wanting to be liked phase) or a period for some who, unfortunately, do not recognise the need to pass the baton to a new generation – the 'retired in office' Principal. Probably the worst outcome is to see those who have achieved success, but have become a pastiche, a shadow of their former selves.

Guideline 5 requires an honest self appraisal of where the HOI is in their career trajectory, where and when they would like to move next (if at all) and the implications of this for themselves, their team and the institution.

Taking stock of where a HOI is in their career is clearly not quite as straightforward as might be implied by the seven stages framework. In the past it perhaps was less important as so often the promotion to HOI was often the final role which was the culmination of a long career in HEIs. Today it appears that more HOI are being appointed at a younger age. Consequently there is potentially a longer career in one or more top jobs. Terms of appointment are also evolving with fixed term (5 years?) with review before a second term becoming more common. Although rare, the option of non renewal for a second term does occur. In both cases the impact of a change of HOI is likely to lead to further change in the TMT.

4.5.2 Career transitions for TMT members

> *"I mean, generally, colleagues who've stood down from VC'ship will have a period to perhaps catch up with their research activities, have a sabbatical period. That would seem the sensible thing to do if they are reintegrating with their academic role. Obviously some people will find that they want to carry on a management role. Some PVCs move on to become VCs elsewhere of course."*

The second stage in the review of career transitions involves 'taking stock' of where each member of the TMT is on their career journey. To assist with this review of the institution's portfolio of talent, it may be useful to consider where team members might be located in their career trajectory.

Table 10 maps two dimensions. The vertical describes the stage of 'maturity' in their role ranging from those at the;

- 'Emergent' stage, probably just about to move from the wider SMG into the TMT.
- 'Developing' stage, probably newly appointed to a role in the TMT.
- 'Maturing' stage, gaining in experience and in the scope of their responsibilities.
- 'Plateauing' stage, very much on top of their portfolio of responsibilities, perhaps needing a new challenge or change in their portfolio, or possibly happy to continue in this position.
- 'Declining' stage, for a range of reasons, the post holder is not performing as well as they have done in the past. Reasons may range from a lack of credibility within the institution, or possibly a desire for change in their portfolio, a lack of success in obtaining a promoted post

(internally or externally) or potentially any number of personal reasons.

- 'Underperforming' stage. Whereas the 'declining' stage can often be short term, this last stage may signal concerns about the long term capability of this member of the TMT.

The horizontal axis represents the primary contribution that the individual is making to the TMT. Is their contribution to assist with the delivery of the academic mission of the institution? Is the person;

- A 'research star', mainly there to assure the institution of the importance of research excellence and to ensure the delivery of high quality research outputs?
- A 'teaching scholar' primarily committed to ensuring the delivery of high quality teaching and learning outcomes?
- An 'entrepreneur' largely focused on the business activities which need to be led by the TMT
- An 'external relationship manager' with significant responsibilities for one or a number of key relationships e.g. stakeholders in the community, international partners, links with regional collaborators etc.
- A 'strategic leader/manager' responsible for one or several major change projects or areas of professional services, or providing expertise in another area of critical importance (capital projects, IT investment etc.)
- An 'all rounder', a generalist, a strong player across several of these dimensions?

Analysis of both the current TMT and possibly the wider SMG might help identify and clarify questions such as;

- Where do we have strength and depth of coverage?
- Do we have any obvious gaps or areas where performance could be enhanced?
- Who may need assistance as they transition into a new role or set of responsibilities? Could external development or executive coaching assist them?
- What more might we do to support those who may need to change their role portfolio or enhance their current level of performance?
- What capabilities may be necessary in the next phase of our development as a team?
- Do we have the capabilities in the existing team, in the institution? Or will we need to consider external recruitment?
- There are many others….

TABLE 10[31]

GRID FOR REVIEWING THE PORTFOLIO OF TALENT IN THE TMT

	RESEARCH STAR	TEACHING SCHOLAR	ENTREPRENEUR	EXTERNAL RELATIONSHIP MANAGER	STRATEGIC LEADER/ MANAGER	ALL ROUNDER	OTHER
EMERGENT							
DEVELOPING							
MATURING							
PLATEAUING							
DECLINING							
UNDER PERFORMING							

31 This can be used a self assessment tool

Guideline 6 is a recommendation to undertake a regular review of the talent required for the current TMT and some consideration of the capabilities necessary for the future. Often part of this occurs during the regular personal development planning and appraisal process - where this exists. Our more holistic process is designed to take a collective view of the overall pool of talent and capabilities across the TMT (and wider SMG).

4.6 Guideline 7: Top team working – orientation and agenda setting

> *[Teamwork] "Well it doesn't just happen. As I say, to get them all to turn up is a good start, which they now do, and to get them all to talk as well. We've got two members on the team, one of whom hardly ever says anything. I mean, when they do, it's very good, but you know, and you can almost put money on who will be the first person to, whatever the item, to chip in with a comment."*

With some initial clarity about the 'what' aspects of TMTs (e.g. roles, functional contributions of TMT members, career transition points etc.) the issues relating to the 'how' can be considered. In particular, we start by considering the process of inducting new team members and of developing 'top team working'.

As discussed earlier, top teams do not engage in team work as a matter of course, and in fact TMT members are likely to spend the majority of their time focusing on their own portfolios. Nevertheless, there are occasions when team work is vital and thus team work needs to be developed, since teamwork is unlikely to simply emerge when it is required.

To deliver on this the team need to also consider the processes and activities which encourage informal interaction, or networking, and social bonding between team members which can act as an important contribution to the development of a more collective approach to decision making. The importance of social interaction tends to be heightened in situations where the team is more dispersed, one or more of the team members are new, or when the team is about to address particularly significant or contentious issues. The task focus of some members of TMTs can lead them to underestimate the value of such apparent 'unproductive time' – time which is in fact likely to be far from 'unproductive'.

In addition to developing the social dimension, it is also important to identify ways in which the team can actively work together on real team issues. Doing so in the short, procedural, and often crowded weekly meetings is normally very difficult. Structuring time away from the normal office environment to discuss the more strategic and potentially open ended agenda items is a very useful way to build and develop the team, although clearly this is heavily influenced by the history, traditions and culture of the particular institution.

In some cases effective top-team working evolves relatively quickly without much real effort. The team culture develops and with some luck a sense of team spirit becomes apparent. However, we sense that this is a process which often requires nurturing, or at least can develop quicker if time and effort is focused on the process. As an example of how this might be addressed, the following is an illustration which emerged during the project. It combines aspects of both the 'what' and the 'how' – the identification of the priorities for action and the processes by which the team would operate.

The TMT of University C had undergone some significant change. The existing DVC had retired and the opportunity was being taken by the VC to restructure the TMT. Rather than replace the deputy, two new PVC positions had been created with portfolios focused on Research and Consultancy and Learning and Teaching respectively to complement the portfolios of the existing two PVC's. To address the 'how' he invited one of us to design and facilitate a workshop for all of the TMT members (6 in total) to take place 2 weeks after the new PVCs joined the institution. Over a period of just over 24 hours (residential) the new team addressed issues relating to;

- 'their first impressions' (including those dating from 24 years to 24 days).
- The strategic priorities (based on the recently published strategic plan) plus their individual and collective accountabilities.
- Their individual and collective leadership styles (informed by pre-workshop completion of a team profile questionnaire.)
- The implications of the team profiles for their approach to working collectively.
- Their collective agenda for the TMT meetings and for those with the wider SMG over the next 12-18 months.
- Their 'ground rules' to inform how they would work together.

The output from the event was a list of over 20 projects to be taken forward by the team after the event. All were judged to be strategically important and priorities for action. Unexpectedly, over half were not currently included in the recently published strategic plan. They have now all been integrated into the plan.

The long term value of this kind of investment remains to be judged. The short term benefits were, however, clear. A powerful induction to the institution, a collective sense of joint ownership for their agenda, an appreciation of how they were planning to work together, and the building of personal relationships formed by the informal discussions over lunch and dinner.

Guideline 7 is a recommendation that team architects make time in the early stages of team formation (and reformation) to integrate new members and to help enhance the degree of team working and collective agenda setting for the new team. We would also encourage the team routinely to stand back and plan their forward agenda of issues on which they will focus their limited time together.

4.7 Guidelines 8-11: Connecting, communicating and acting collectively

"I think there still are, there's some sense, I would say, of distance, between the [Top Team] and the organisational chalk face."

No TMT is an island. Even the most successful TMT will fail if they do not build connections with other (formal and informal) teams in the institution. In some cases, however, there is 'only' the SMG – there is no top team – thus the connections are 'expected' to be made through large meetings and line management structures. The number of connections necessary will therefore vary depending on the structure of the institution. Whatever framework exists, careful thought is required. Some of the most common connection points we have identified are as follows;

4.7.1 Connecting with heads of academic units and directors of professional service functions.

"….from the last staff attitude survey, there was a sense of, I suppose there is in every organisation, a sense of some distance, that staff felt between them and the top team, and there was quite a big complaint that people hadn't been involved sufficiently in the development of strategy across the University, and this time around they made a real, really big effort to involve staff in the development of our next strategic plan, and we ran, it all came out of the away days actually, interestingly, the kind of concept of running the strategy development as a project, but being as open and consultative as we possibly could."

"There will be regular meetings with the heads of schools, probably once every couple of months we get them in, and I suppose, effectively update them [about] issues on which we have current concern, developmental issues and so on, for discussion, and they can bring items to the agenda as well. […..], directors of services are able to come to that meeting, along with the heads of schools, can sit in with that, and a number of them do, and that's quite a useful communication device"

The extent of communication linkages depends on whether those who head the largest academic units (colleges, faculties or schools) or who head the major professional service functions are full time members of the TMT. As identified previously the 'two tier' model of a small inner cabinet and a wider extended SMG is an increasingly common structure. This is the classic 'deans and directors' dilemma. Do we have them 'all in the tent all the time' or if not, how do we connect with them when 'we're in our tent' and 'they are in their tents?'

Responding to this connection challenge typically involves creating fora which will enable the connections to be developed. These might, for example, be referred to as the SMG, the Corporate Management Team, the Senior Management Conference, etc. The best of these are highly effective events where really important issues are debated, new initiatives are fostered and policies agreed and decisions taken. The least effective examples are top down presentations about relatively unimportant issues, where initiative is frowned upon and where decisions are rarely, if ever, made. Achieving the former rather than the latter requires careful planning and process management.

As an example of the latter, the following example emerged during our study.

University D recently changed its approach by adopting a different style to these events. Prior to the change there existed an informal grouping, which met every week and was known as the 'Monday Morning Meeting' and a wider Executive Board which met fortnightly. Although formally the latter was identified as the TMT, informally it was felt that the former was

where the real decisions were taken and where the real action was. Over time the EB became perceived to be less important and its effectiveness diminished. Suspicion and distrust began to develop between the two groups.

Working with the well regarded director of HR in a consulting capacity a number of interventions took place to remedy the situation. Relevant to the "Deans and directors dilemma" a new approach to the connections between the two groups was designed. Rather than the MMM group repeating the agenda they had at the next EB meeting it was agreed to experiment with an alternative model. The MMM would continue, however, the schedule of EB meetings would reduce and be supplemented by a series of four facilitated 'EB awayday' meetings. The agenda and issues debated at the awaydays would include input from the heads of each academic unit on a rotating basis plus input from PVC's on major cross cutting topics (research, internationalisation etc.)

Again the longer term value of this change will take time to evaluate. However in the short term it helped, in addition to other interventions, to build the connections and two-way communication between the top team and the wider audience.

Guideline 8 is a recommendation that careful thought and routine review takes place to assess the effectiveness of the communication and degree of connection between the TMT and its wider constituents (be they formally constituted as a SMG or not).

4.7.2 Connecting with the council / board of governors

"I suppose the other comment to make for your understanding is we share pretty well all our business with the lay members, obviously the people who are chairing and sitting on these committee, there's very little they don't know about us. I mean, the Management Board shares a lot of information with them, and they're taken into confidence and so on, because I think that way you get the best value from them."

The connectivity 'upwards' varies in its extent and its perceived importance. In a formal, constitutional sense the connections to the Council/Board may be limited to the HOI, although there are increasing examples of participation by TMT members with the governing body. Informally, however, connections to and with the Council/Board may often involve all members of the TMT. Whether these connections are with the 'top team' or are focused more on the 'individual' agendas of those in the TMT is often an important test of whether the TMT is acting with team like intentions. Through those interactions the governing body will both implicitly or explicitly reach judgements about the perceived level of teamworking taking place among TMT members.

Guideline 9 for our top team architects is a reminder to ensure sufficient time is given to assessing collectively how the process of connecting to the Council/Board is being handled. Inconsistencies in the delivery of key messages, ambiguities on critical issues or members of the top team having conflicting agendas which play out at Board meetings will ultimately limit effectiveness of the top team in the eyes of the Board. It is also not only through direct presentations that these differences are communicated. Body language, seating arrangements, the language and tone of response to questions all send signals about how well the top team is working together.

4.7.3 Connecting sideways with other 'Top Teams'

"[….] notes are produced on a weekly basis, which are circulated around the management board (MB), and also the ….. Group, this group who direct […] they receive an edited version of the notes. So they're all certainly in the loop. That used to be one of the complaints I suppose, that communication about what MB was thinking was not always terribly clear, so we thought we would disseminate that rather more around the directors, to keep them plugged in, and also to alert them to issues and to be able to say to them look, this is an issue that's emerging, we need you to be engaged on working on some aspect of it for example, and make them immediately see what MB has been thinking, or is seeking to do. "

The connectors with other internal 'top teams' are also an important issue for architects of the TMT. Higher education differs from other contexts in having a number of 'top teams' or their equivalent. For the senior level policy and resources issues and executive level decision making, the top management team in the forms we have been describing has primacy. However, for other vitally important issues, the committees responsible for shaping the policy prior to its more formal endorsement by the top team are important constituencies with whom to interact, often well in advance of the issue and reconnecting with the top team at some later stage.

Decisions about which other 'top team' groups to connect with as a TMT will vary significantly between institutions. Sometimes a less than impressive sounding sub-committee may have a much more significant role than might be suggested by its formal status. In other instances, bodies such as Senate or Academic Board may be less important than perhaps they should be in governance terms.

Guideline 10 is a reminder to the TMT to consider relationships with other internal bodies to ensure that the TMT is well connected with the agenda and activities of each significant sub- group.

4.7.4 Connecting outwards with external stakeholders

Much of the work of the TMT involves connecting formally and informally with external stakeholders. These range from Funding Bodies, Research Councils, Regional Development Agencies, the political (and planning) bodies at a town/city level, national or regional representative bodies (e.g. the Russell Group) formal partnerships/alliances (e.g. the N8) and so on.

In many instances the value of these external connections can be lost to the institution or appear haphazard or uncoordinated, if:

- There is confusion about who in the TMT is responsible for coordinating the specific relationship
- There is limited opportunity to feed back the intelligence gained from such meetings
- The distilled benefits are not communicated
- The intelligence gained by others outside of the TMT who are involved through research and other activities has no easy conduit for its communication to the TMT

The final bullet point is particularly important in the higher education sector given the influence academics can have through their field of enquiry. In addition in a small community, and some larger communities, the connections which all employees of a University have can, in the local context, be a further source of intelligence, power and influence.

Guideline 11 is a call for regular reviews of the external connections which take place and for the TMT to regularly check the internal conduits, for upward communication about external links from others in the institution.

4.8 Guideline 12: Team behaviours and team roles

"I think it works well. I think it's largely down to the HOI, who, as I say, has got a very nice style, a really, really good style [….]. If he sees tensions he kind of lets it go its course, but then gets it to move on, and I think also the fact that we end at ten, you know, I think there must be nothing worse than to be cosseted for the whole morning, with people just sort of going at each other."

Having established an effective framework that ensures the TMT is spending its time on the right issues, it is as important to ensure the team has both a good appreciation of, and encourages the behaviours which enable, effective team working (when this is needed). To do so requires a process of determining a set of relevant and explicit 'ground rules' which help guide and encourage positive reactions within the team. For example, one TMT identified the senior leadership framework shown in Figure 4 (opposite) to describe the way in which the TMT should aim to operate. At a more detailed level this was used by the team to make more explicit the desired behaviours team members should exhibit, where the team were in relation to these, and what more was required to enhance the level of team working.

To achieve the business goals, senior leaders need to first manage themselves (1). Thereafter they are in a position to engage and support others (2) and through effective communication (3), lead the business strategically (4) and create an institution that people are loyal to (5)

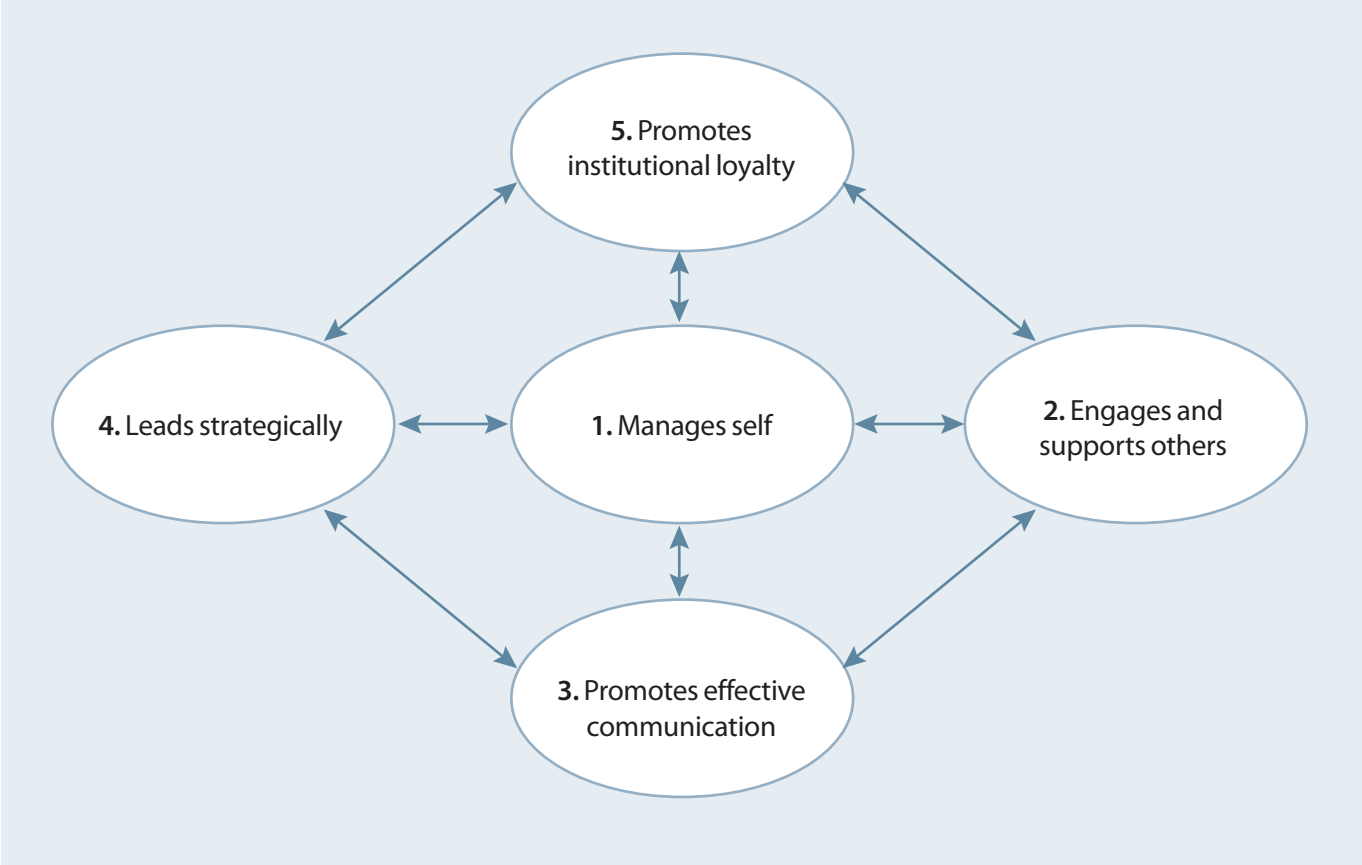
In addition to making explicit how the team will operate, it is also useful for the TMT to jointly agree on the potential consequences which will apply when one or more individuals do not operate according to the agreed ground rules.

A further aspect of the 'how' dimension of the top team is its awareness of the behaviours it recognises as important for it to fulfil its various functions. Is it primarily a 'task' focused body, highly formalised in its operation, or does it recognise and give attention to the need for a broader range of behavioural and team thinking capacities to be both encouraged and fostered?

"I mean, to some extent, a more harmonious team has actually created a different dynamism, a different culture. It's not entirely harmonious, but nonetheless, it's……you can't expect people to agree on everything, but nonetheless it's, you feel there's a reasonable amount of give and take, and people are working hard and doing their best to serve the university, and although we may joke about things sometimes, we all feel that he's a jolly good vice-chancellor."

FIGURE 4

SENIOR LEADERSHIP BEHAVIOURAL FRAMEWORK



Bensimon & Neumann's [32] study of how presidents of US HEIs developed and used their top team highlighted three distinctive types of activity as outlined in Table 11 overleaf.

From this work they discriminated between 'real' and 'illusory' teams. Illusory teams are identifiable by the extent to which the latter two and particularly the third components were absent from the work of the team.

The facilitation of the team's cognitive function is an area we would echo as being a significant component of the work of the top team architects. To quote Bensimon & Neumann, 'Presidents are likely to find the cognitive function to be the most challenging, if not the most problematic to develop within the team. Yet of the three functions, this is without doubt the most critical. 'Simply put, in its cognitive function the team is a brain like social structure that enlarges the intelligence span of team members.'[33]

The question of what characterises 'team' thinking and how to develop it is an interesting question. The US researchers usefully created an interesting typology to describe the eight thinking roles they identified in the teams they analysed. These roles are described in Table 12 overleaf.

From our work we would corroborate these descriptions as a useful framework to highlight the value and need for diverse thinking styles in a top team.

Guideline 12: recommends that top team architects review more frequently the top team and consider the expressive and cognitive aspects of its working, consider and discuss the degree of complementarity which exists within the team thinking aided or not by the Bensimon & Neumann framework, and finally consider whether a more explicit set of behavioural 'ground rules' might help the team to operate even more effectively.

32 Bensimon & Neumann's (1993)
33 Bensimon & Neumann (1993) p41

TABLE 11

TEAM FUNCTIONS IN TOP MANAGEMENT TEAMS[34]

TEAM FUNCTION	IMAGE	PURPOSE	BEHAVIOUR	ACTIVITIES
1. Utilitarian	*Formal*	Help achieve a sense of rationality & control.	'Task Related'	Deliver information coordinate & plan. Make decisions.
2. Expressive	*Social*	Help reinforce a sense of 'groupness'.	'Integrative'	Provide mutual support. Provide counsel to the president.
3. Cognitive	*Sense making*	Enlarged span of intelligence of individual team members. Enable group to behave as a creative and corrective system.	'Intellectual'	View problems from multiple perspectives; question, challenge, argue; act as monitor and feedback systems.

TABLE 12

EIGHT THINKING ROLES FOR A PRESIDENTIAL TEAM (AFTER BENSIMON AND NEUMANN, 1993)

ROLES IN THE "CORE" OF TEAM THINKING	
Definer:	Voices a view of the team's reality and thereby creates that reality
Analyst:	Provides a deep examination of issues previously defined (e.g. by assessing components of a problem)
Interpreter:	Translates how people outside the team are likely to see and understand issues at hand
Critic:	Offers redefinition, reanalysis, or reinterpretation of issues facing the team
Synthesiser:	Elicits diverse thinking roles and facilitates the construction of a summative team reality
ROLES THAT SUPPORT THE "CORE":	
Disparity monitor:	Assesses how people outside the team will react and make sense of the team's actions
Task monitor:	Strives to remove obstacles to team thinking, facilitates the team's work processes in general
Emotional monitor:	Helps to establish and maintain the human, personal, and emotional context within which team thinking occurs

34 Bensimon and Neumann (1993)

4.9 Guidelines 13-14: Location, logistical support and resources

Further dimensions to the 'how' of team working include issues relating to the location of team members and the logistical support and resources provided to the team, individually and collectively.

Several interviewees commented on the importance of physical location in facilitating the degree of informal interaction between team members and providing access to shared support (e.g. support and research staff, information, and facilities). In some cases, the benefits of being co-located with shared support was viewed as a major advantage, and in others open plan working was seen as particularly effective (although in other contexts physical constraints may exist which preclude such an 'executive office' model). In other institutions, particularly those where TMT members were part-time and had responsibilities or an academic home elsewhere in the institution, the benefits gained from co-location were not so easily achievable. However, on balance, it appears that there are clear benefits from the co-location of the TMT, where this is feasible.

The important advantages of regular informal interactions which occur when senior leaders share some (or all) of a common space we believe will outweigh the potential disadvantages of disconnection from their academic or professional community.

However, the location issue has other dimensions, in particular the symbolism associated with the space inhabited by the TMT and how it is, or will be, perceived by the staff and visitors. On our visits to many institutions such symbolism is perhaps more visible or apparent to the casual observer than to the team themselves.

- How accessible is the location? In the centre of the campus on another site disconnected from the institution?
- Is it in the most attractive part of the campus, e.g. near the lake or on the top floor of the main administrative building?
- How formal or informal is the location?
- How many gatekeepers or layers of security exist between staff and the office of the vice-chancellor? Do you enter through a security coded doorway?
- Does everyone have separate offices along a long corridor, or is a more open plan environment dominant?
- Is the décor glitzy and does it feel 'extravagant'? Or is it in need of redecoration and somewhat 'down-beat'?
- Is the welcome friendly and informal or overly formal and intimidating?

All of these scenarios exist, and some teams are clearly aware and have designed the office to send very explicit signals, others seem less aware or ignore the somewhat negative messages the space inhabited by the TMT may be sending to their staff and visitors.

Guideline 13 for our TMT architects is a simple one. Be aware of the signals your location and its surroundings are sending. They matter.

Related to the location issue is the level of infrastructure provided to the TMT. A pattern has emerged in the past five years or so involving a move from a reliance on two or three personal assistants (PA's) to support the TMT, to the provision of additional executive assistants, programme managers, change managers, and project managers to support the work of the TMT. This is partly a consequence of the increasing volume of work to be coordinated and led, but also a growing recognition of the need for professional support for delivery of the work of the TMT.

However, the political and symbolic implications of such decisions also need to be considered:

"[…..] one of the big issues here is about the centre not being seen to grow disproportionately, and I think that's actually quite a good discipline, that people keep a very close eye on, you know, where there's an extra post advertised, where's that come from?"

Guideline 14 for our TMT architects is to think about the infrastructure support to the team, what support would enhance the capacity of the team and enable its members to focus on the important thinking and strategic level influencing work (rather than finding their time eroded by more operational / administrative issues). Such assistance is also needed to ensure that they have the information required to make the key decisions.

4.10 Guideline 15: Performance management & evaluation – individually and collectively

> *"In essence, I judge it on – I set certain tasks, typically five or six in any year, it just happens to work out like that, and I can evaluate it at the end of the year. [….] So I will have those objectives which I can judge, but there are also what I call the kind of ten commandments, which everybody has to abide by."*

The process of 'performance managing' a TMT is a further issue which confronts any changes in the structure, composition or size of a TMT. It is also a matter complicated by the need to manage both individual and collective performance.

4.10.1 Managing individual performance

Managing individual performance is relatively straightforward although the process varies considerably across HEIs from the highly informal annual chat (quite common) to the highly formal biannual performance review (becoming more common). For the top team to be effective it is important to ensure that individual members are clear about their role, and the particular responsibilities associated with that role. Clarity is critical for managing the performance of each member of the team. Short, focused and well-defined role descriptions which are subject to regular review and updating are of particular value. More informal and/or ambiguous role descriptions that are not regularly reviewed are clearly less valuable and may often lead to confusion and, in time, conflict within the team.

Conflict may occur unintentionally through oversight, or in some cases provoking conflict could be more intentional. The HOI may perceive that a degree of 'creative tension' is necessary within the TMT with more than one individual working on a specific issue. However, a degree of ambiguity can also exist, when there is ineffective negotiation between individual team members, and it is therefore desirable that someone (the HOI or another senior role holder) arbitrates along the boundaries of the issue and regularly negotiates the responsibilities of each member of the senior team. The regularity of such reviews varies significantly according to: the degree of change in the team; the magnitude and complexity of the issues facing the team together; and the degree of 'fit' between the team member and their portfolio of responsibilities. The importance of clear descriptions is of particular relevance when new people join the team or the portfolio of one or more of the team changes.

Performance management at the individual level in a TMT - whether formal or more informal - requires time and planning. The once a year informal review, the twice yearly review of objectives and planning for the next year, or the thrice yearly set of meetings - the third focusing on career development and succession issues - need to be integrated into diaries with the same attention as the regular TMT meetings.

4.10.2 Managing collective performance

Performance management at the collective level in a TMT is - we believe - a much less well developed process. This is even more so when the matter of reward is also added to the challenge. There are some key questions to answer when considering how to assess the collective performance and effectiveness of a TMT, for example:

- What constitutes high performance?
- What criteria should be used to judge the success of a TMT?
- Should the process be a self-evaluation or could it also benefit from external review?
- What measures should be used? – is it primarily about personal and team performance or does it also need to connect to measures of effectiveness, such as whether the TMT is making a difference to institutional performance?
- What importance should be paid to how the group performs as a team compared to how individuals perform against specified individual objectives and targets?
- Does team performance really matter or is it primarily individual performance that gets rewarded?
- What is the relative importance of individual, collective (TMT) and institutional performance in assessing performance and where they exist in relation to performance related payments (PRP). The present study did not explicitly examine this matter, it does, however, appear to be an area which could benefit from further analysis.

Evaluation of the effectiveness of academic, processes the delivery of higher education is a well, and some would argue overdeveloped area of activity. Evaluation of the effectiveness of top teams, we would argue, is a much less well developed area.

In our study we came across some, albeit limited, examples of TMTs evaluating their team effectiveness and performance. Mostly this was of an informal nature involving 'taking soundings', but in some cases a more formalised review and feedback process was used. In some instances the use of a 360 feedback approach has been used to capture evidence of the performance of the VC and top team, typically after a period of 12 -18 months working together. Respondents from different constituencies were invited to complete a questionnaire, the data being collected confidentially and presented back as a composite perspective from the particular groups. In our conclusion section we also highlight other more developmental processes which can be used to review the performance of a TMT against a series of criteria relating to its effectiveness.

Guideline 15 is a recommendation that TMTs discuss how they will assess their own success and consider more explicitly the performance management processes and evaluation techniques they plan to use, how much time they plan to devote to this issue, and who and how frequently reviews should be undertaken at an individual and collective level.

4.11 Guideline 16: Team development

In this final guideline we highlight the processes which might be used to aid the development of a TMT to help it achieve and maintain a high level of effectiveness. Often, having formed the TMT, (by considering the guidelines relating to clarifying motives, roles, career transition points, behaviours, performance criteria, and logistical support) the team is left to its own devices as far as team development is concerned. It is assumed that the process of moving from 'forming' through to 'performing' will occur relatively quickly (which it may well do). In other instances it may never occur, or the team may get stuck at one of the common intermediate stages of team development – the 'storming' or 'norming' stages. Team working, particularly at the top, is as one writer commented 'an unnatural act'[35] – any activity which can help make it become more 'natural' and commonplace is worth considering.

As highlighted above, sometimes that intangible sense of team spirit develops without too much effort; team members define and negotiate successfully their individual and collective contributions to the achievement of the team's objectives. Decisions are reached through debate and recognition of individual differences of view, constructive dissent is encouraged and valued. When differences arise they are resolved through open dialogue. When new challenges arise which cross the boundaries (or require coordination) between the portfolios of team members, these are constructively explored and through mature judgement a positive way forward is obtained. Where team members are having difficulties, other team members provide support.

Of course, the alternative can also occur in terms of lack of team spirit. Turf wars dominate, individuals vie for the attention of the HOI, political infighting becomes routine, differences of opinion are not welcomed, dissent lies hidden, and how and where decisions are reached is opaque in the extreme. 'Bad behaviour' (e.g. personal attacks against other team members, point scoring, undermining other team members, or arguing about insignificant issues, etc.) become the norm. Poor performance is not tackled and becomes accepted practice.

In both cases,team development can be helpful. In the first case to enhance an already high performing team and in the second to help an inadequate team recognise itself as such and begin the process of building trusting relationships and collective ways of working, which may eventually create a sense of team based working.

Team development as an explicit process for TMTs in HEIs is a relatively new activity. Informally, most high performing teams have engaged in processes which may well be considered as team development activities (without necessarily recognising them as such). For example, spending time socially getting to know each other, being inducted into the ways of operating within the TMT by one of the longer serving members of the team, regularly reviewing how the team is operating collectively and so on.

Moving towards a more explicit approach to team development requires careful thought and action. Handled badly by, for example, poor analysis of the needs of the team, inadequate understanding of the context of higher education, a lack of skill in facilitating dialogue at a top team level, inappropriate or badly timed interventions will all lead to unsuccessful outcomes and permanently damage the credibility of those responsible for the process. Thankfully, there are also examples where team development has been sensitively facilitated using relevant and timely processes which have led individuals to understand each other better, groups to gel and become teams and overall team and institutional performance to improve significantly.

Team development is a topic involving a wide range of perspectives and processes, ranging from those steeped in the more psychotherapeutic world of group dynamics to other approaches which use the real work of the team itself as the basic building blocks on which to develop the team. In other cases the approach may be more focused on analysing evidence of how the team operates collectively using any one of a number of different frameworks.

For example, the factors highlighted below (adapted from Francis and Young[36]) and based on a related questionnaire, have been used to provide a helpful evidence base from which to discuss the performance of a TMT. Data of this type gathered in advance of a team development intervention (and collated and presented without attribution), can be very helpful in identifying areas of strength, areas

35 Herb et all (2001)

36 Francis and Young (1993)

recognised by all team members as issues needing to be enhanced together with issues identified by team members as being seen very differently by team members. Facilitating a conversation to identify the potential team development needs of a TMT is, normally, assisted and supported by this type of evidence. In this case the 9 criteria and the behaviours and evidence which relate to highly effective and poor perceptions of team working are as follows;

1. Climate

Team discussions are open: team members say what they think and feel. Discussion is 'robust' and there is no undercurrent of manipulation or of people playing politics. Proposals, not people, are attacked. Ideas and proposals are constructively confronted. There is a high level of energy. Team members look upon different viewpoints as a valuable source of stimulation.

2. Influence

The team has real influence, with sufficient autonomy to make important decisions about individual projects and the management of all its activities.

3. Team meetings

Formal and informal discussions have an appropriate degree of structure and order. Time and effort are invested in preparation. The objectives of meetings are crystal clear and all members understand their roles.

4. Relationships

Members of the team listen to each other. They seek to understand each others' viewpoints. Team members help each other and share information. Barriers to cooperation are detected and broken down. There is a high level of trust between team members and interpersonal 'games' are absent.

5. Taking a wider perspective

Short-term concerns are not allowed to dominate the work of the team. Members are personally committed to thinking beyond the needs of the immediate project and consider the broader needs of the organisation.

6. Team decision making

There is a balance of skills which enables the team to interpret relevant information about its activities. During discussions, information is efficiently collated and understood. Effective techniques for problem solving and decision making are practised. The team is able to work with complex issues and arrive at well-considered conclusions.

7. Team creativity

There is open-mindedness in the team. Old habits and assumptions are vigorously questioned for relevance today. Radical ideas are heard and considered, as are innovative thinkers, both in and outside the team. Experiments are set up to test new thinking. The team takes risks and accepts that there will be some failures.

8. Judgement

The team is 'in tune' with the needs of its community. The team has a view of the overall strengths and weaknesses of the organisation and understands the damage that will be caused by foolhardy or over-optimistic decisions. There are thorough team reviews of the efficacy of past decisions and lost opportunities. Resource allocation decisions are well considered prior to commitment. The team seeks feedback on its effectiveness and maintains a solid practical orientation.

9. Direction and feedback

The team manages its activities effectively. Information and control systems to support this are well developed and enable decisions to be effectively implemented. Project related information flows readily up and down so that potential problems are rapidly detected.

Based on some initial diagnosis, possibly involving a questionnaire survey, or a number of one to one discussions with team members, it will then be appropriate to design an appropriate process of team development.

In addition to team development activities informed by such surveys, the team should also consider how it can use the work of the team as team development. The Higher Education Academy/Leadership Foundation for Higher Education 'Change Academy' offers one model by which teams working on an institutional change project can gain insights into the process of change management and the processes which aid team working. Similarly, spending time together focusing on a significant institutional issue (ideally in a context different from the normal schedule of team meetings) can prove to be extremely valuable. Not only does quality time get devoted to issues of real importance, but the process of working together itself in an intensive manner can also be very developmental and foster stronger team working capabilities.

Herb, Lesley and Price[37] characterised the team development challenges facing top teams as being of three different types. First they need a common direction, second, good quality

37 Herb, Lesley and Price (2001)

TABLE 13

COMMON TEAM DEVELOPMENT REQUIREMENTS AND ISSUES ARISING (HERB ET AL, 2001)	
REQUIREMENT	**ISSUES ARISING WHEN DEVELOPMENT IS REQUIRED**
1. Clear Direction	**(a) Lack of alignment.** Implementation of the strategy is fragmented and lacking in coherence.
	(b) Lack of deep understanding. Decisions when taken are based on superficial assumptions and are not challenged nor are the wider consequences of the decisions considered in any depth.
2. Effective Interaction and Dialogue	**(c) Poor dialogue.** Team members fail to communicate effectively by withholding vital information suppressing opinions or accepting questionable strategies for fear of attack.
	(d) Dysfunctional behaviours. An inability to capitalise on diverse viewpoints and backgrounds. Fear, defensiveness and 'scapegoating' become normal, and because they are not challenged such practices are mimicked lower in the organisation, and eventually become pervasive.
3. An Ability to Renew	**(e) Personal dissatisfaction.** Frustration and a lack of challenge dominate, and performance begins to decline as team members seek new pastures.
	(f) Insularity. The focus of discussions becomes largely inward looking, new insights or information from outside which challenge the team's perspectives are not welcomed.
	(g) Deficient individual skills. Support and development for the new challenges they face in the team are very limited and hence gaps in the skills base arise.

skills of interaction and dialogue and third, the ability to renew themselves. Table 13 above summarises the common team development issues which a lack of capacity in each of these areas may lead to. The authors rightly emphasise the importance of building capacity in each of these three areas, since a lack of capability in any one area is sufficient to seriously limit the effectiveness of the team.

Guideline 16 is therefore a suggestion for TMTs to consider their development as a team. To engage, routinely, in collective processes which offer insights into their working patterns, which allow the 'taken for granted' assumptions about the way the team works to be discussed and which ultimately can lead to team development processes which can enhance team performance for the benefit of the whole HEI.

5 Conclusions: Reflections, further research and leadership development

We conclude by reflecting on some lessons of experience gained during this project and on our suggestions for other issues on which further research would be of value to the higher education sector. We also offer some suggestions in relation to approaches and topics which may assist members of the TMT with their ongoing leadership development.

5.1 Reflections

Before ending, we return to an issue we raised earlier and three other matters. The first, raised earlier, is who should be the architect of change in the TMT? The second, some reflections on the relative importance of the formal top team structure compared with more informal approaches, and the third is to consider the concept of 'structured networks'[38] as a framework for considering top team structures.

In relation to the first issue, where responsibility for making change to the top team structure should rest, historically this has been very much the domain of the HOI. When a new team has to be created, when a new HOI joins an institution, when urgent action is needed to help and/or remove an underperforming member, then there is a strong case to suggest the HOI should exercise his/her judgement on the matter. In other instances when the TMT has worked together for some time, when the need for collective action is required, when the views and opinions of the whole team are important, then we would argue there is a need for decisions relating to the team to be taken by the team.

The second reflection relates to the relative importance of the formal top team structure compared with more informal networks. Throughout our study, whilst we were primarily concerned with the formal structures which exist in relation to top teams, we were also very aware of the importance of the many and varied informal networks which permeate a HEI and which can be highly influential. As mentioned earlier, some of these less formal groupings can have a disproportionate impact that might be perceived from their location (if indeed they are identifiable) in the formal hierarchy of decision making bodies. The ability both to acknowledge and engage in a constructive sense with these informal networks of stakeholder groups, without creating a subversive alternative cabinet is perhaps an important feature of the more effective TMTs. Focusing exclusively on the formal without also seeking to understand the informal structures could be a significant limiting factor for a top team.

On the third issue, Goold and Campbell[39] - reflecting on organisational design more generally - introduced the concept of 'structured networks' to describe an alternative to the more conventional hierarchical and matrix forms of structure found in many HEIs. They suggest that such structural approaches can provide enough, but not too much structure. We sense this approach might have relevance for architects of top teams. The benefits of a structured network TMT would be to recognise the importance of collective working without moving fully towards a strongly hierarchical, top down approach. Table 14 opposite summarises the pros of their concept of structured networks compared with matrix structures.

5.2 Research

Based on our experiences during this project we highlight five areas relating to top structures in UK higher education - where there may be value in conducting further research.

5.2.1 Changing patterns - undertaking sector wide questionnaire surveys

The genesis of this study was the interest in the topic of top team structures. A consistent theme of interest has been a desire to understand the many and varied top team structures across the sector and a quest to seek out an 'ideal structure'. In our early conceptualisation of this study a significant focus of our investigation was also linked to this search. Our desire to undertake a comprehensive questionnaire survey was partly a reflection of our desire to seek out potential optimum structures.

As our research evolved, however, the notion of any 'ideal' top team structure or belief that a range of exclusively 'structural' options existed began to diminish. Apart from the increasingly wide ranging diversity of institutional types across the higher education sector in the UK, it became increasingly apparent that a much wider range of factors influenced the design of an appropriate top team structures. This is, however, not to conclude that a questionnaire survey would not be a helpful piece of further research. A survey could be very useful but it would probably be of more value when the outcomes from one institution are compared with other similar institutions, as part of a benchmarking exercise for example. Crucial to the process is the permission of the audiences who will participate in the survey – and a process of engaging a key individual from each institution early in the design and development process. A key lesson of experience is that to undertake detailed sector wide surveys of the type we were proposing was unrealistic in the time frame we set. Significantly more time than we anticipated needs to be invested in involving key individuals in shaping the

38 after Goold and Campbell, (2003)

39 Goold and Campbell (2003)

TABLE 14

STRUCTURED NETWORKS (GOOLD AND CAMPBELL, 2003)		
DESIGN CHALLENGE	**STRUCTURED NETWORKS**	**DRAWBACKS IN TRADITIONAL MATRIX STRUCTURES**
1. Responsibility definition	Enough clarity on roles, but not too much detail	Either confusion or excessively detailed definitions of responsibility
2. Interdependence and mutual learning	Enough interdependence and mutual learning, but not too much pressure to conform	Compromises for specialist cultures
3. Coordination and linkages	Enough solutions for difficult links, but not too much interference with voluntary networking	Coordination processes and initiatives which take too long and don't pay off
4. Accountability	Enough recognition of shared responsibilities, but not too much dilution of individual responsibility	Costly monitoring and weakened commitment to deliver
5. Hierarchy	Enough hierarchy to add value, but not too much cost and interference	Redundant hierarchy that destroys more value than it adds

research, in demonstrating the value and benefits which would ensue from such an exercise and in reassuring the participants about how the data and the outcomes from the exercise would be used.

Proposal 1 for further work would, therefore, be to invite existing "mission groups" of similar types of institutions (e.g. the Russell Group, the '94 Group etc.) to consider the value of more limited surveys of their members using a variant of the questionnaire instrument outlined in the appendix to this report. We believe this could be a value added service to their members and a process which could be of real benefit to the sector.

5.2.2 Changing roles

The period during which the study was conducted appears to have coincided with a time of considerable change in the roles of senior staff who are typically members of the TMT or the wider SMG (or perhaps it was always thus). We identified a number of these roles (e.g. AVCs, new professional service roles such as in IT/IS, HR and Finance) and changes in existing roles (e.g. executive deans and DVCs). We also highlighted that changes in these roles are also likely to have a wider impact on the workings and relationships within the TMT (e.g. the impact on the registrar's role in a unitary structure). These are all areas which could benefit from further investigation. The outcomes from several of the other Leadership Foundation funded research projects will shed further light on these emergent patterns and we may collectively be able to offer some new insights.

Proposal 2 is for further work to be undertaken which focuses, in some more detail, on a limited number of roles in the TMT which are identified as facing significant change and considers what impact these changing roles may have on the composition of the TMT.

5.2.3 Recruitment, selection and induction

The growing importance of the process of recruiting and selecting members to join an existing TMT is a topic of which we became aware during our study. Whilst a separate topic to that of composition, it can often be a central element in the effectiveness of the team. To our knowledge it is a topic on which there is limited documented research or other evidence. Key questions include: What are the most effective methods of recruitment? What processes are most effective at the selection stage? What role should the existing team members play in the process? What, if anything, can be done to assess the impact of new members of the team on the workings of the TMT? And finally, how can new members of the TMT be inducted into the team so as to ensure they can 'get up to speed' as quickly as possible.

Proposal 3 for further work would be an investigation into the strengths and weaknesses of alternative approaches to the recruitment, selection and induction of top team members. This could also usefully involve further work involving 'search and selection' agencies which are active in the higher education market.

5.2.4 Top team reward

In the process of considering the performance and effectiveness of the top team, the matter of performance related reward emerged as a topic where there is strong interest. Performance related pay is already a well established practice in many HEIs – with additional bonus payments to members of the TMT for enhanced performance becoming increasingly common. Central to designing a fair, transparent and effective PRP scheme is a mechanism for agreeing criteria for assessing the effectiveness of the TMT and of setting and reviewing personal and team objectives on a regular basis. Again, this is a topic on which there appears to be limited knowledge, and limited transparency.

Proposal 4 would be for further work to be undertaken to review the current approaches to linking reward to individual, team and institutional performance at the most senior levels in HEIs.

5.2.5 Team development

Over the period of this study there was a sense of more frequent use of internal and external facilitators to assist TMTs with their development, individually and collectively. The establishment of the Leadership Foundation alone has no doubt encouraged more institutions to consider the benefits of a range of interventions. However, to date there has been no systematic study of the alternative approaches to team development which exist, the benefits of each and the value of developing tools and techniques which could be of value for the sector.

Proposal 5 would be for a study of the range of team development techniques in use in the higher education sector to assist TMTs in HEIs, to be considered for support by a relevant funding body.

In addition to areas for further research related to top teams themselves, there would also be benefit in reflecting on the potential value of other leadership development activities for those individuals aspiring to, or already members of, the senior or TMTs.

5.3 Leadership development

The Leadership Foundation already provides a range of developmental programmes for those aspiring to, or already members of, the SMT or TMTs. These programmes offer participants exposure to a range of developmental issues, experiences and networking opportunities (such as the TMP, SSL, PSSL etc.[40]). To complement the existing range of offerings there may be merit in developing other forms of support, for example:

Executive Coaching – A small, but increasing number of HEIs offer members of the TMT access to an external coach typically on their appointment to the TMT and during their early period in the role. There could be value to be gained from evaluating the experience to date of this type of process and to broadening the provision of such support beyond its current provision.

Top Team Induction & Skills Development – A growing number of HEIs already provide opportunities for senior staff to participate in leadership development experiences, often in collaboration with colleagues in other institutions. Building on this there may be merit in offering a limited number of short, 1-2 day programmes which are exclusively for those about who have just joined or are about to enter the TMT. These events would supplement the induction processes within the institution. In addition to focusing on some of the issues which arise on joining the TMT, workshops could also be offered which explore specific areas where different skills may be necessary related to the TMT.

Again these would be additional to activities already provided through institutions or via existing programmes. Illustrative topics might include;

- Dealing with the media
- Strategic influencing and negotiating capabilities
- The art of strategic networking
- Dealing with difference constructively
- Developing collaborative partnerships – internally and externally
- Financial analysis and decision making
- …amongst others

Cross Sector and International Comparisons – One final topic for consideration would be to examine the value of gaining insights into the workings of TMT by looking at TMTs sectors, or in a very different cultural context. In the former

40 Top Management Programme (TMP), Senior Strategic Leadership Programme (SSL), Preparing for Senior Strategic Management Programme (PSSL)

there may be value in understanding how TMTs in other 'intellect based organisations' (e.g. professional service firms, research organisations etc.) operate. In the latter case there may be value to understanding how TMTs in HEIs, in for example Scandinavia or Australia operate. What are the common challenges, what new insights can be gained from these experiences?

Our final *Proposal 6* therefore is to invite the Leadership Foundation to consider these suggestions for future leadership development for TMT members.

5.4 Summary of guidelines and proposals for action

In summary, Table 15 outlines set of practical guidelines for top teams to use as a review framework. As highlighted at the beginning of the report, the process of reviewing the top team structure and making changes is a multi-faceted issue. Our framework is intended to be as comprehensive as possible so as to reinforce the intended consequences and minimise the impact of any potentially unintended consequences.

We would encourage TMTs to review all of these and jointly judge their relative importance. We would particularly encourage all TMTs to add the issue of 'top team working' to their agenda on at least an annual, if not more frequent, basis. Team working at the top is too important an issue to be left to chance.

TABLE 15

THE 16 TMT GUIDELINES

GUIDELINE	ISSUE	KEY QUESTION(S) PROPOSAL	PRIORITY
1	**Rationale and motive(s)**	• Why do we want to change our TMT structure? • What are our real motives? **Proposal:** Clarify the surface and more deep seated reasons for change. Consider the value of using one or more mentors and trusted advisors to explore this highly personal and 'un-discussable' issue.	
2	**Role(s) & role expectations**	• What do our stakeholders expect of the TMT today and in the future? **Proposal:** Clarify and prioritise the functional role expectations for the TMT today and in the future.	
3	**Purpose: decision making & time management**	• What are the critical institutional priorities which can only be achieved through integrated and collective action? • On what issues does the TMT recognise that mutual rather than individual accountability is crucial? **Proposal:** Ensure open and transparent debate takes place to identify those issues on which it is crucial that the TMT operate as a team and then devote adequate time to these issues.	
4	**Succession management**	• What capacities will we need in our TMT in the future? • Who might be able to supply these? • How do we develop their capacity? **Proposal:** Make time to discuss as a team the future succession management challenges facing the TMT.	

TABLE 15

THE 16 TMT GUIDELINES (CONTINUED)			
GUIDELINE	ISSUE	KEY QUESTION(S) PROPOSAL	PRIORITY
5	**Career transitions: for the HOI**	• Where is the HOI in their career development? • Which stage best describes where they are and where they might be moving towards? **Proposal:** Make time to dispassionately take stock of where your HOI is on their career trajectory and consider the implications for the shape and roles required in the TMT.	
6	**Career transitions: for the TMT members**	• What is the collective pool of talent in the TMT? • Where is each member on their career trajectory? • What capabilities will be important to the success of the TMT now and for the future? • Where do we have potential gaps? **Proposal:** Routinely undertake a talent audit to assess where members of the TMT are on their career journey and consider the implications for the TMT.	
7	**Top Team working: orientation & agenda setting**	• What should we be spending our limited time discussing and making decisions about in the TMT? • How do we introduce and induct new members into the TMT? **Proposal:** Make time to regularly review and jointly determine the future agenda for the TMT, and consider how to help new members to quickly become productive members of the TMT.	
8	**Connecting, communicating and acting collectively with the HEI**	• How can we best engage with, and connect to, the other teams below the TMT? **Proposal:** Make time to engage in regular and meaningful dialogue with the wider academic and professional service teams which report through to the TMT.	
9	**Connecting, communicating and acting collectively with the governance bodies**	• How do we as a TMT engage with, and communicate individually and collectively, with our Council/Board of Governors? **Proposal:** Ensure sufficient time is given to collectively discussing the process of connecting through to the Council/Board.	
10	**Connecting, communicating and acting collectively: horizontally**	• Which other internal bodies/committees are important to the successful achievement of the work of the TMT? • How well connected are we to these? **Proposal:** Consider which internal bodies are of most significance and ensure that the TMT is well connected with the agenda and activities of these other bodies.	

TABLE 15

THE 16 TMT GUIDELINES (CONTINUED)			
GUIDELINE	ISSUE	KEY QUESTION(S) PROPOSAL	PRIORITY
11	**Connecting, communicating and acting collectively: externally**	• With whom do we need to communicate externally? • Who are our most important external stakeholders and clients? • How do we capture institutional knowledge about external organisations? **Proposal:** Ensure regular reviews of the external bodies of most importance and check that internal conduits for communication to the TMT about external links are open and working effectively.	
12	**Team behaviours and team roles**	• Have we recognised the importance of the 'process' and 'cognitive' dimensions to the work of the TMT? • Do we value the benefits of alternative team roles? • When do we need to bring others into the TMT to provide new expertise or skills? **Proposal:** Take time to review and consider how the team is performing and which team roles are dominant and which may be missing.	
13	**Location, logistical support and resources**	• Where should the TMT be based? • How open and accessible is the location for the TMT? **Proposal:** Be aware of the signals your location and its surroundings are sending – they matter.	
14	**Location, logistical support and resources**	• What sort of support and facilities should be provided to the TMT? **Proposal:** Consider the infrastructure support to be provided to members of the TMT, and consider what other resources might help the team be even more effective.	
15	**Performance management & evaluation**	• How should the performance and effectiveness of individual TMT members and of the collective TMT be undertaken? **Proposal:** Make time for regular (at least once/year, if not more frequently) formal reviews of the performance of each member of the TMT. Consider the criteria which define success for the TMT as a whole. Review team performance against these on a routine basis.	
16	**Team development**	• What more could we do to enhance our ability to work effectively as a team? • What resources for personal and collective development activities are available to help the TMT remain or enhance its effectiveness? **Proposal:** Ensure that the team sets aside adequate time for routine team development activities which will inform and enhance the performance of individuals and of the team. Provide adequate resources for such activities.	

Take a moment to evaluate your own institutional TMT against these 16 issues, in priority terms which are High (H) – in need of urgent attention, Medium (M) – OK but could be improved, or Low (L) – strengths which it is important we retain. What does the pattern suggest as possible actions? Who else needs to be consulted to address the issues?

To conclude, our aim has been to highlight some of the key issues which we believe, if considered seriously, will enhance the design and process of TMT working in HEIs. Perhaps then the term top leadership team (TLT) might be more commonly used – or where it already exists teams will feel more comfortable using this to describe what, in essence should be a central feature of their collective responsibility.

We also hope we will have made a modest contribution which will help minimise the worst excesses of inappropriate, unnecessary and ill-considered restructuring. This is, of course, not new and so aptly captured by Petronius the Arbiter in 66 AD when he said

'we trained hard… but it seemed every time we were beginning to form up into teams, we would be reorganised. I was to learn later in life that we tend to meet any new situation by reorganising: and a wonderful method it can be for creating the illusion of progress while producing confusion, inefficiency and demoralisation'.

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APPENDIX A
THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM DIAGNOSTIC REVIEW QUESTIONNAIRE

1. Background

As part of this research project we developed a questionnaire which could be adapted for use as a detailed diagnostic instrument by the architects of top teams in higher education institutions, to enable them to review their top team structure in some of the ways described in the report above. The outcomes from the questionnaire, it is hoped, will provide some helpful insights and perspectives that can assist institutions in the review and redesign of their TMT. The questionnaire would also be a useful tool for consortia or groups of institutions to use as a basis for comparative benchmarking studies related to top teams.

We distributed an early version of the questionnaire to a small number of contacts in HEIs, the Leadership Foundation and a selection of TMP fellows who were asked for their feedback on the following issues:

- Ease of understanding the questions (e.g. clarity of language, question wording)
- Logic of structure
- Questionnaire flow
- Length and time required to complete
- Content (e.g. suggestions for additions/removal)

Following a number of amendments, the questionnaire was then sent to all members of the Universities Personnel Association (UPA) (Personnel/HR directors) in late 2006/early 2007. UPA members were asked if they would discuss the questionnaire with colleagues in their SMT to see they would complete the questionnaire and provide feedback to the project researchers on the ease (or otherwise) of completing the survey.

2 Lessons from the piloting exercise

The piloting exercise generated a range of very useful comments and the main lessons learnt are summarised below:

a) Length and complexity

Unsurprisingly, a key issue raised during the piloting exercise was the length and complexity of the questionnaire. Although the majority of questions were seen as relevant, it was felt that completing the questionnaire would require a significant investment of time on behalf of the institution, and the involvement of several individuals and departments/units.

b) Institutional support

Related to the issue above, it is evident that a detailed questionnaire of this sort requires demonstrable benefits for institutions in completing the questionnaire in terms of relevance, rationale and identifiable outcomes. Using the questionnaire would require a key individual in an institution to 'champion' the data collection exercise, reassuring the participants about how the data and the outcomes from the exercise would be used, and leading the review and interpretation of the findings.

c) Opinion/attitude questions

Some of the questions in the questionnaire are opinion/attitude questions where the responses are likely to differ depending on the role and background of the person completing the questionnaire. Different people in different roles are likely to have different knowledge about and perspectives related to the TMT. Therefore, consideration has to be given to whether the TMT answers such questions as a group (e.g. following a workshop exercise), whether different TMT members complete such questions individually, or whether questions are answered by targeted individuals based on their role and expertise.

d) Terminology

It also became clear early on in the piloting exercise that the terminology used in the questionnaire meant different things to different people and in different institutional contexts. For example, not all potential respondents were familiar with the term 'top management team' and roles such as 'DVC' and 'PVC' mean different things in different institutions. This meant that a number of respondents felt unable to answer particular questions. Therefore, when using the questionnaire it is important that such terms are clarified at an early stage, and perhaps a discussion of the meaning of key terms could be used as a first stage to help identify which parts of the questionnaire are relevant to the institution.

e) Suitability for a sector wide survey

Given the complexity and length of the survey, and the lessons described above, we decided that it would be unrealistic to undertake a detailed sector wide survey on this topic. Perhaps a shorter questionnaire collecting some basic information would elicit a reasonable response, but at a cost of losing the contextual detail that would render the

findings useful for the sector as a whole. We believe that an adapted version of the questionnaire is best used as a benchmarking tool for similar types of institution, or by an individual institution seeking to review its top team structure.

3 The questionnaire structure

The questionnaire is organised into the following four parts, each containing a number of separate sections:

1. Respondent Information
2. Academic, administrative and governance structures
3. Composition of the 'senior management group' and 'top management team'
4. Nature, responsibilities and processes of the 'top management team'

The first part was designed specifically for the piloting exercise, and will not be relevant for institutions using the questionnaire internally, although it may be useful when using the questionnaire for comparative work.

The second part focuses on contextual information about the institution, and collecting this information is likely to be a useful exercise for all institutions, since not all of this data will be widely known or collected together in one place.

The final two parts focus directly on the TMT and are likely to require more consideration - as such questions are unlikely to have been asked before.

4 Using the questionnaire

The questionnaire has been designed for completion electronically (it has several optional responses to several of the questions) to reduce the length of the questionnaire and hopefully make it easier to complete.

Please note, an electronic version of this questionnaire can be found on the Leadership Foundation website at http://www.ifhe.ac.uk/publications/research.html

QUESTIONNAIRE THE COMPOSITION, CHALLENGES AND CHANGES IN THE TOP TEAM STRUCTURES OF UK HIGHER EDUCATION INSTITUTIONS

This questionnaire has four parts:

- **Part 1** asks for **contact information** for a relevant individual within your institution.
- **Part 2** seeks to collect some information about the **academic, administrative and governance structures** in your institution
- **Part 3** seeks to collect some information about the **composition** of the senior management group and of the 'top management team' within your institution.
- **Part 4** seeks to collect more detail about **the nature, responsibilities and processes** related to the 'top management team' within your institution.

Information for Respondents

The questionnaire has been designed to be completed electronically by entering information into the grey boxes in each section. You can move from one grey box to the next box by using the TAB key.

- Where the grey box is **blank**, information can be added by simply clicking with the mouse on the grey box and typing. You can type as much as you like in each box, since the box will expand as you type.
- Where the grey box contains the **text 'select one'** this means that there is a drop down menu from which one option only can be selected by clicking on it with the mouse. To access the menu simply click on the down arrow at the side of the box.
- Where the grey box is a **small square box** ☐ this can be checked simply by clicking with the mouse in the box.

Leadership Foundation
for Higher Education

PART 1: RESPONDENT INFORMATION

Please could you provide the contact details for a relevant person in your institution that we can contact to discuss the information provided in this questionnaire?

1. Contact name
2. Position / Title
3. Institution
4. Department / Unit
5. Telephone number
6. Email address

Please note: The information in the table above is only being asked for profiling purposes. Any responses in the following sections will not be attributable to any named individual in any reports or publications that result from this research.

PART 2: ACADEMIC, ADMINISTRATIVE & GOVERNANCE STRUCTURES

SECTION 1: ACADEMIC STRUCTURE

In the following questions we would like to find out about the nature of the academic structures within your institution.

1. In the third column of the table below please could you provide the name of:

a) The top level academic unit in the academic structure in your institution (e.g. Faculty, School, etc.)? Please type the name in the box provided
b) The names of the other main types of academic unit in the academic structure in your institution (e.g. Research Institutes, Schools, Departments, etc.)? Please type the names in the box provided

2. In the fourth column of the table below please could you provide:

a) The number of top level academic units listed in question 1a. Please write the number in box provided
b) The numbers of each of the other types of academic units listed in question 1b. Please write the number in box provided

		NAME	NUMBER
a)	**Main academic unit** (E.g. School, Faculty, etc.)		
b)	**Other Academic Units** (E.g. Department, Division, School, Research Institute, etc.)		

PART 2: ACADEMIC, ADMINISTRATIVE & GOVERNANCE STRUCTURES (CONT...)

SECTION 1: ACADEMIC STRUCTURE (cont...)

3. In the next set of questions we would like to find out about any recent or planned changes to the academic structures in your institution.

a) In the first row in the table below please could you select the option that best describes any changes the number of top level academic units in your institution that have taken place in the **last 3 year**s? Please select one of the options below, and could you also provide a description of the change in the box provided (e.g. a move from 3 to 5 Schools, or a move from 3 Faculties to 6 Schools).

b) In the second row in the table below please could you select the option that best describes any changes to the number of top level academic units in your institution that are planned to take place in the **next 2 years**? Please select one of the options below, and could you also provide a description of the change(s) in the box provided (e.g. a move from 3 to 5 Schools, or a move from 3 Faculties to 6 Schools).

		DESCRIPTION
a)	**Changes in the last 3 years**	
b)	**Planned changes in the next 2 years**	

In addition, if a chart that describes the academic structure of your institution is available, then we would be very grateful if you could provide a copy to us either electronically or in hard copy.

4. In the table on the following page we would like to find out some more information about the top level academic units within your institution.

a) In the first column could you write the **names** of each of the top level academic units in your institution (e.g. School of Management, etc.)?

b) In the second column could you provide the **job title of the head** of each of the academic units listed in 4a (e.g. Dean of School of Management, etc)?

c) In the third column could you provide the **approximate number of staff** (FTEs) in each of the academic units listed in 4a?

d) In the fourth column you provide the approximate **number of students** (FTEs) in each of the academic units listed in 4a (if applicable)?

e) In the fifth column you provide the approximate **total income** per annum (in £s) for each of the academic units listed in 4a?

f) In the final column you provide the approximate **research income** per annum (in £s) for each of the academic units listed in 4a?

Note: We have provided an example in the first row of the table.

If you require any extra rows please feel free to unlock the form and copy and paste further rows at the end of the table. Please let us know if you require any further assistance with this process.

A) NAME	B) HEAD OF UNIT	C) NO. OF STAFF (FTEs)	D) NO. OF STUDENTS (FTEs)	E) TOTAL INCOME (£)	F) RESEARCH INCOME (£)
School of Management	*Head of School of Management*	*180*	*800*	*£2m*	*£500k*

PART 2: ACADEMIC, ADMINISTRATIVE & GOVERNANCE STRUCTURES (CONT...)

SECTION 2: ADMINISTRATIVE STRUCTURE

In the following questions we would like to find out about the nature of the administrative structures within your institution.

1. Which of the following statements best describes the structure of the top level of 'administration services' (i.e. administrative/professional/corporate services) in your institution? Please base your response on the descriptions of each type provided below and select one option from the drop-down list.

- Unitary – where all administrative service heads are accountable to and report directly through one senior administrative role
- Binary – where all administrative service heads are accountable to and report directly through two senior roles (e.g. the Head of Administration (i.e. Registrar) and the Finance Director)
- Ternary or Tertiary – where all administrative service heads are accountable to, and report directly through, three senior roles (e.g. the Head of Administration, the Finance Director and the Secretary)

	DESCRIPTION
Type of administrative structure	
Other type of administrative structure (if applicable)	

2. In the table below please could you provide the titles of a) the Head of 'administration services' and b) the titles of the other senior post holders in the structure that you described above?

	TITLE
Head of Administration Services (e.g. Registrar)	
Other senior post holder(s) (e.g. Finance Director)	

SECTION 3: GOVERNANCE STRUCTURE

Now thinking about the governance and management responsibility structures in your institution.

1. What is the name used in your institution for the post of Senior Administrative Support to the Governing Body (Council, Governing Board) – typically referred to by the title Secretary, Clerk to the Board etc.? Please enter the name used in your institution for this role in the box below.

2. To which of the following posts does this post report? Please check all boxes that apply.

Vice Chancellor/Principal (or equivalent) ☐
Registrar/Head of Administration ☐
Other (write in below) ☐

PART 3: COMPOSITION OF THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM AND SENIOR MANAGEMENT GROUP

In this part of the questionnaire we are interested in finding out more about the senior management group (SMG) within the institution, and the formal or informal smaller group of individuals who may be referred to as the inner 'top' management team (TMT).

1. Based on the descriptions provided below, could you provide the name of a) the relevant 'senior management group' and b) the 'top management team' in your institution (if applicable)?
   Please write the names in the in the boxes provided below.

   Senior Management Group
   All higher education institutions have a senior executive decision making body that is responsible for making the most significant operational decisions and implementing the strategic actions agreed with the Governing body of the institution. This group is typically referred to as the VC's Advisory Group, the Executive Board, the Corporate Management Group, etc.

   Top Management Team
   In many higher education institutions a smaller group of post holders exist, formally or informally, to take more immediate day to day operational decisions and to consider high level strategic issues prior to consideration by the wider senior management group. This group is often referred to as the 'top management team'.

	NAME IN YOUR INSTITUTION
Senior Management Group	
Top Management Team	

2. How many people are permanent members of a) the Senior Management Group and b) the Top Management Team in your institution? Please write the number in each in the boxes below :

Senior Management Group	
Top Management Team	

3. In the table on the following page(s), we would like you to provide some information about the people in your institution that are members of the senior management group (SMG) and/or the top management team (TMT).

a) In the first column please could you write the job title of each person who is a permanent member of either the SMG or the TMT (i.e. all of the people who are a member of one or the other)?

For each of these people we would be grateful if you could fill in some further details about their role in columns b) to i):

b) In the second column, please could you describe the functional responsibilities of their particular role (e.g. International Strategy, Teaching and Learning, Estates, etc.)?
c) In the third column, could you describe any academic/professional responsibilities they may have (e.g. Head of School of Social Sciences, Head of Student Services)?
d) In the fourth column, could you provide us with some information about the type of post this person holds (e.g. Permanent, Fixed Term, etc.)?
e) In the fifth column, if the person holds a fixed term appointment, could you let us know the length of the term?

PART 3: COMPOSITION OF THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM AND SENIOR MANAGEMENT GROUP (CONT...)

f) In the sixth column, could you tell us the date the person was appointed to their current role (month and year)?
g) In the seventh column, could you tell us from where the person was appointed (e.g. internal, external)?
h) In the eighth column could you indicate whether the person is a permanent member ('Yes'), an invited, or a non-member ('No') of the SMG?
i) And finally, in the ninth column, could you indicate whether the person is a permanent member ('Yes'), an invited, or a non-member ('No') of the TMT?

Note: We have provided an example in the first row of the table.

If you require any extra rows please feel free to unlock the form and copy and paste further rows at the end of the table. Please let us know if you require any further assistance with this process.

A) TITLE	B) FUNCTIONAL RESPOSIBILITIES	C) ACADEMIC/ PROFESSIONAL RESP.	D) TYPE OF POST	E) TERM	F) DATE APPOINTED	G) RECRUITED FROM	H) SMT	I) TMT
PVC Research	*Research & Enterprise*	*Line Manager – School of Engineering*	*Fixed Term - Renewable*	*3 years*	*June 2004*	*Internal*	*Yes*	*Yes*

A) TITLE	B) FUNCTIONAL RESPOSIBILITIES	C) ACADEMIC/ PROFESSIONAL RESP.	D) TYPE OF POST	E) TERM	F) DATE APPOINTED	G) RECRUITED FROM	H) SMT	I) TMT
PVC Research	*Research & Enterprise*	*Line Manager – School of Engineering*	*Fixed Term - Renewable*	*3 years*	*June 2004*	*Internal*	*Yes*	*Yes*

PART 4: THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM

SECTION 1: TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM MEETINGS

In the following series of questions we are in interested in finding out more about how the top management team operates within your institution.

1. Meetings Process

a) Who chairs the meetings of the top management team (TMT) in your institution? Please could you provide job title of the person in the box below
b) Which of the following best describes how frequently the TMT typically meets? Please select one response in the table below
c) And on which day of the week does TMT Team typically meet? Please select one response in the table below
d) And where do the meetings of the TMT typically take place? Please could you describe the location in the box below
e) And finally are non-members of the TMT invited to the meeting from time to time to contribute to specific agenda items? Please select one response in the table below

a) Chairperson	
b) Frequency of meeting	
c) Day of meeting	
d) Location of meeting	
e) Invited members	

2. Agenda and Minutes

a) Which of the following best describes how the agenda for TMT meetings is formulated within your institution? Please select one response in the box below
b) And which of the following best describes how the minutes of the TMT meetings are circulated within you institution? Please select one response in the box below

a) Agenda	
b) Minutes	

SECTION 2: CONSTITUTION, ACCOUNTABILITY & COMMUNICATION

1. Constitution
Which of tatements best describes the constitution of the TMT in your institution?

If the TMT does have Terms of Reference, and if they are easily available, please could you append these TOR to this questionnaire when you return it to us (either electronically or in hard copy)?

2. Accountability & Reporting

a) To which of the following authorities is the TMT accountable (i.e. reports to)?
Please check all boxes that apply

- Vice Chancellor/Principal (or equivalent) ☐
- Council/Governing Body ☐
- Senate/Academic Board ☐
- Planning & Resources Committee (or similar) ☐
- Other (write in below) ☐

b) Which bodies (e.g. groups, committees) formally report to the TMT? Please could you provide the names of these bodies in the box below

3. Communication

Now thinking about the communication between the TMT and the rest of the institution.

a) In which of the following ways are the decisions made by the TMT communicated outside the TMT?
Please check all boxes that apply

- Via the line-management structures ☐
- Via the publication of the TMT minutes or briefing documents ☐
- Via TMT membership of Senate/Academic Board ☐
- Via TMT membership of a senior administrative/professional services co-ordination group (e.g. Registrar's Central Services Group) ☐
- Via TMT membership of sub-committees of the governing board ☐
- Via a formal team briefing process ☐
- Other (write in below) ☐

b) And how does the rest of the institution feed into the discussions of the TMT?
Please check all boxes that apply

- Via the line-management structures ☐
- Via the publication of the TMT minutes or briefing documents ☐
- Via TMT membership of Senate/Academic Board ☐
- Via TMT membership of a senior administrative/professional services co-ordination group (e.g. Registrar's Central Services Group) ☐
- Via TMT membership of sub-committees of the governing board ☐
- Via a formal team briefing process ☐
- Other (write in below) ☐

PART 4: THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM (CONT...)

SECTION 3: RESPONSIBILTY, FUNCTION AND STYLE

1. Responsibility

How would you rate the TMTs level of responsibility for the each of the following areas of activity in your institution? Please select one option for each activity.

Strategic-Internal

a) Design of the Institutional Resource Allocation Model
b) Decisions relating to areas of strategic investment and divestment
c) Review and changes to organisational and committee structure

Strategic-External

d) Monitoring financial performance and redistributing resources
e) Monitoring implementation of operational plan
f) Coordinating all significant change projects – capital and revenue related

Operational-Internal

g) Horizon scanning and scenario planning
h) Direction setting, clarifying strategic position & determining high level priorities
i) Creating and coordinating links with key stakeholder relationships

Operational-External

j) Review of benchmark comparison with peers and competitors
k) Managing relationships with significant funders, partners and clients
l) Demonstrating the institution's role in its region and local community

2. Function & Style

a) On a scale of one to ten how do you perceive the **function** of the TMT within your institution - where 1 refers to a more 'corporate' (i.e. joint collective & mutual accountability for decisions) function and 10 a more 'advisory' (i.e. providing collective input for decisions taken by the VC and the Chief Financial Officer) function? Please select a number between 1 and 10 in the final column below

b) On a scale of one to ten how do you perceive the **style** of the TMT within your institution - where 1 refers to a more 'directive' style and 10 a more 'consensual' (i.e. highly collegial) style? Please select a number between 1 and 10 in the final column below

a) Function	Corporate	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	Advisory
b) Style	Directive	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	Consensual/ Colegial

SECTION 4: TRAINING, DEVELOPMENT AND SUPPORT

1. Training & development for TMT members

We would now like to find out some information about any leadership and management training & development that members of the TMT have received.

a) Which of the following types of **internal** leadership and management training and development have one or more members of the TMT in your institution participated in within the last 12 months? Please check all boxes that apply

b) And which types of **external** leadership and management training and development have one or more TMT members in your institution participated in within the last 12 months? Please check all boxes that apply

	a) Internal	b) External
Leadership Development	☐	☐
Management Development	☐	☐
Team Development	☐	☐
Executive Coaching	☐	☐
Secondments	☐	☐
Shadowing	☐	☐
Non Executive Directorships		☐
None of these	☐	☐
Other (write in below)	☐	☐

Other Internal	

Other External	

c) On a scale of 1 to 10 how do you perceive the **culture** of leadership and management training & development for TMT members within your institution - where 1 refers to a culture where training and development is not considered appropriate and/or relevant for the TMT and 10 refers to a culture where the institution is highly committed and supportive of training and development? Please select one number in the final column below

Culture	Not relevant/ appropriate	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	Committed and supportive

2. Support for TMT members

And which of the following other types of support for their activities have one or more members of the TMT in your institution received in the last 12 months? Please check all boxes that apply

Resources for short term consultancy support	☐
Research support	☐
Administrative support (e.g. Executive Assistant) – for individuals	☐
Administrative support (e.g. Executive Assistant) – shared by TMT	☐
Dedicated secretarial support	☐
Staff seconded from elsewhere from the institution	☐
Other (write in below)	☐

PART 4: THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM (CONT...)

SECTION 5: CURRENT AND FUTURE CHALLENGES FOR THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM

In the following set of below we are interested in your perceptions of the importance, and of your TMTs performance, on a range of key tasks and processes typically undertaken by the TMT in higher education institutions.

1. Firstly, how would you rate the following key tasks typically undertaken by the TMT in terms of:

a) Their **importance** as tasks to be undertaken by the TMT in your institution - where 10 indicates an extremely important task, and 1 represents a task of very limited importance. Please select a score out of 10 for each task in the second column below

b) The **performance** of your TMT on these tasks - where 1 indicates an extremely poor performance and 10 represents an extremely strong performance. Please provide a score out of 10 for your TMTs performance on each task the third column below

	IMPORTANCE (out of 10)	**PERFORMANCE** (out of 10)
Design of the Institutional Resource Allocation Model		
Decisions relating to areas of strategic investment and divestment		
Review and changes to organisational and committee structure		
Monitoring financial performance and redistributing resources		
Monitoring implementation of operational plan		
Coordinating all significant change projects – capital and revenue related		
Horizon scanning and scenario planning		
Direction setting, clarifying strategic position & determining high level priorities		
Creating and coordinating links with key stakeholder relationships		
Review of benchmark comparison with peers and competitors		
Managing relationships with significant funders, partners and clients		
Demonstrating the institution's role in its region and local community		

2. Secondly, how would you rate the performance of your institution's TMT on the following key processes that impact upon the effective working of the TMT? Please provide a **score out of 10** for your TMTs performance on each process, where 1 indicates an extremely poor performance, and 10 represents an extremely strong performance.

	PERFORMANCE (out of 10)
Recruitment of members to the TMT	
Clarifying and defining adequately the roles and responsibilities of members of the TMT	
Managing the agenda for TMT meetings to ensure focus on the most important issues	
Integrating the work of individual members of the TMT	
Time and diary management to ensure TMT activities are progressed	
Communication between members of the TMT	
Communication between the TMT and the SMG	
Team working within the TMT	
Team working between the TMT and the SMG	

3. Now looking into the future, can you tell us below what you believe will be the greatest challenges likely to confront the TMT in the next 1-2 years?

SECTION 6: RECENT AND FUTURE CHANGES FOR THE TOP MANAGEMENT TEAM

In the final set of questions below we are interested in any changes that have recently taken place, or which are planned, related to the form and function of the top management team in your institution.

1. Could you please provide details in the space below of any changes to the TMT in your institution, if any, those have taken place in the past 5 years? (e.g. roles, responsibilities, size, TOR)

2. And finally, could you also provide details in the box below of any other changes to the TMT which you are planning to take, if any, in the next 1-2 years?

FINAL COMMENTS

Thinking about the questionnaire as a whole, are there any issues related to Senior Management, and Top Team structures that we have not covered in this questionnaire, and which you think are important for us to consider? If so, could you please provide brief details about these in the box provided below?

Many thanks for completing this questionnaire.

If you have any further queries about any aspect of the questionnaire, please contact **Steve Woodfield** at the University of Surrey on (01483) 683125 or via email at: s.woodfield@surrey.ac.uk

BIOGRAPHIES

Dr Tom Kennie

Dr Tom Kennie is a director of the Ranmore Consulting Group and a visiting professor at Nottingham Business School and with the School of the Built Environment at the University of Salford. He is also joint programme director of the Leadership Foundation for Higher Education Top Management Programme (TMP). He has worked across the higher education sector on a wide range of senior leadership development programmes, top team development projects, coaching for members of senior management teams and facilitation of strategy events.

Steve Woodfield

Steve Woodfield is a Senior Researcher in higher education policy and management at Kingston University, and during this project he also worked as a Research Fellow at the Centre for Policy and Change in Tertiary Education (CPC-TE) at the University of Surrey. Over a number of years he has undertaken a range of research projects on issues related to policy and management in higher education, particularly related to institutional leadership and strategy development, and internationalisation in higher education both in the UK and internationally.

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